



‘GRASSROOTS GOVERNANCE’

Ladakh districts to get autonomous councils

NEWS » PAGE 10

TRAGIC PARTY

At least 27 killed in Bangkok bar fire

WORLD » PAGE 14





SECURITY RESEARCH

‘UMANG portal flaws exposing user data’

NEWS » PAGE 11

DATA POINT

The question of illegal migrants

The claim that border districts host increased migration is misleading

OPINION » PAGE 9



A DAY TO CHERISH

India scripts historic Test win at Lord's

SPORT » PAGE 15

Citizenship decisions must be ‘fair, reasoned’, says SC

Top court sets aside 27 judgments of Gauhati HC on ‘foreigners’, asks tribunals to adjudicate afresh; Citizenship declarations can’t be sustainable if ‘procedure adopted is mechanical’, says the court

Aaratrika Bhaumik
NEW DELHI

The Supreme Court on Monday held that the determination of citizenship and foreigner status must be undertaken through a “fair, lawful, and reasoned” process, as it set aside a batch of 27 Gauhati High Court judgments declaring the appellants to be foreigners, and remanded the cases to the Foreigners’ Tribunals concerned for fresh adjudication.

A Bench of Justices Vikram Nath and Sandeep Mehta observed that while the state has a legitimate interest in ensuring that persons who are legally ineligible for an Indian citizenship do not obtain such a status through “false claims”, the “grave conse-



A state action which is arbitrary cannot claim the protection of law merely because it is clothed in statutory form. A proceeding which may result in a person being declared a foreigner cannot be sustained if the procedure adopted is mechanical, one-sided, or devoid of application of mind

SUPREME COURT JUDGMENT

quence” of being declared a foreigner must follow a procedure that adheres to constitutional guarantees.

Fair opportunity
“A state action which is arbitrary cannot claim the protection of law merely because it is clothed in statutory form. A proceeding which may result in a person being declared a foreigner cannot be sus-

tained if the procedure adopted is mechanical, one-sided, or devoid of application of mind,” the judgment, authored by Justice Nath, said. The Tribunal must examine whether the person had a “fair opportunity, whether the main grounds were disclosed, whether the evidence before it was capable of supporting the reference, and whether the

conclusion follows from the material on record,” it added.

The HC had dismissed the appeals against the orders of the Foreigners’ Tribunals declaring the appellants to be foreigners after noting that none of them had appeared before the tribunals despite having been served notices. It had observed that, in the absence of any written statement, documents, or evidence from the appellants, the tribunals had “no option” but to affirm the references.

The top court, however, clarified that the remand should not be construed as an affirmation of the appellants’ claim to Indian citizenship.

CONTINUED ON
» PAGE 10

NEARBY



6 killed, 40 hurt as buses collide in Madurai

MADURAI
Six persons were killed when an omnibus collided with a TNSC bus near Karungalakudi on the Madurai-Tiruchi Highway in Madurai district on Monday. Forty passengers and crew members of both buses were injured. The police said the omnibus driver lost control of the vehicle, which jumped over the median and rammed the TNSC bus coming on the opposite lane. Three passengers of the State transport corporation bus were killed on the spot.» **PAGE 6**

Retail inflation climbs past RBI target to 4.4%

T.C.A. Sharad Raghavan
NEW DELHI

India’s retail inflation has crossed the Reserve Bank of India’s 4% target for the first time since January 2025, touching 4.4% in June. It stood at 3.93% in May.

Inflation, as measured by the new series of the Consumer Price Index (CPI), was driven by rising food and fuel prices amid the crisis in West Asia as well as a weaker-than-normal monsoon. Food inflation touched 5.05% in June, the highest in the new series of the CPI. The transport segment saw inflation rising to 4.3% in June, compared with 1.7% in May, following rise in fuel prices.

“The June CPI inflation

Trade deficit jumps 430% as imports surge

NEW DELHI
India’s trade deficit grew over fourfold to \$15.3 billion in June primarily due to high growth in merchandise imports, which were skewed by a spurt in the value of imports of crude oil, and gold. » **PAGE 13**

of 4.4%, exceeding the RBI’s medium-term target of 4%, reflects persistent pressures from global geopolitical uncertainties and supply chain disruptions,” said Vivek Rathi, national director of research at Knight Frank India.

CONTINUED ON
» PAGE 10

U.S. ‘taking over’ Strait of Hormuz, says Trump

Agence France-Presse
WASHINGTON

U.S. President Donald Trump said on Monday that his country was reinstating its blockade of Iranian ports and “taking over” the Strait of Hormuz, where it would levy charges on shipping, as the two sided traded strikes in a scale unseen since an April ceasefire. Iran’s military command, meanwhile, insisted on Monday it would not allow the U.S. to “interfere” in the key conduit for oil and gas, while also warning its Gulf neighbours against cooperating with Washington.

FULL REPORT ON
» PAGE 14

Ram Temple donation case: SC seeks report

Krishnadas Rajagopal
NEW DELHI

The Supreme Court on Monday directed the State of Uttar Pradesh to file a status report on the ongoing probe into the Ram Temple donations’ embezzlement case, and sought the Shri Ram Janmabhoomi Teerth Kshetra Trust’s response on petitions seeking to hand over the case to the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI).

A three-judge Bench headed by Chief Justice of India Surya Kant agreed with an oral request made by Solicitor-General Tushar Mehta, appearing for both the Union and Uttar Pradesh governments, to

not issue formal judicial notice to them.

Mr. Mehta offered to submit a status report on the investigation into the case in a sealed cover. The law officer said the State had already constituted a Special Investigation Team (SIT) and the probe was well under way with arrests made.

Acquiescing, the Bench said the status report should contain the details of the composition of the SIT and must be filed on July 20, the next date of hearing.

CONTINUED ON
» PAGE 10
CEO APPLICATIONS
» PAGE 11

SC stays Madras HC’s ban on cow slaughter

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Supreme Court on Monday stayed a May 27 order of the Madras High Court that directed the Tamil Nadu government to enforce a State-wide prohibition on the slaughter of cows and calves.

A Bench comprising Justices Vikram Nath and Sandeep Mehta was hearing a special leave petition filed by the Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam (TVK)-led government challenging the High Court’s order on the ground that the direction was contrary to the provisions of the Tamil Nadu Animal Preservation Act, 1958, which permits the

slaughter of cows over 10 years of age if a competent authority declares them unfit for work and breeding. Observing that the impugned order required *prima facie* “correction”, the Bench issued notice on the appeal filed by the State government and stayed the operation of the High Court’s order insofar as it directed the State to impose a complete ban on cow slaughter.

The State apprised the top court that the High Court’s order amounted to “judicial lawmaking” and was internally inconsistent.

CONTINUED ON
» PAGE 10

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INBRIEF



Inner Wheel Club, SNEHA take up mental health project

The Inner Wheel Club of Madras Midtown, a women-led organisation with a 50-year legacy, and SNEHA, an NGO specialising in suicide prevention, will collaborate on a mental health initiative to conduct teacher training programmes in schools in remote areas. The initiative will run alongside community outreach and grief support sessions, which will be conducted in adopted villages to raise awareness and foster healing through Survivors after Suicide (SAS) groups. Lakshmi Vijayakumar, founder of SNEHA, Rama Vaidyanathan, the 51st President of the Club, and Supriya Sundaraman, Chairman of Inner Wheel District 323 spoke about the mental health initiative.



CPI State secretary urges govt. to protect Puzhal Lake

CPI State secretary M. Veerapandian on Monday urged the Tamil Nadu government to erect a fence around Puzhal Lake, one of Chennai's primary sources of drinking water, to prevent dumping of waste and other forms of pollution. After inspecting the lake, Mr. Veerapandian said he was shocked by its condition. "The lake should be protected from turning into a dumping ground and a site for open defecation. It requires proper fencing and adequate security, as it is a vital source of Chennai's drinking water," Mr. Veerapandian said.

12 inmates escape from Govt. Place of Safety, one arrested

They escaped while a movie was being screened for the inmates. Later, they robbed motorists of two-wheelers, mobile phones, and cash

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Twelve inmates escaped from a Government Place of Safety in Athur near Chengalpattu and later attacked motorists on road before fleeing on two-wheelers, taking mobile phones and cash. One of the escapees, a 19-year-old from K.K. Nagar, was arrested early on Monday, while the police are searching for the remaining 11.

The Government Observation Home and Place of Safety, functioning under the Social Welfare Department, houses more than 70 juveniles and young offenders aged between 18 and 21 from across Tamil Nadu.

According to police sources, several rival groups operate inside the institution. About 10 days ago, a violent clash broke out between two groups, following which cases were registered against 19 inmates. More than five inmates had escaped from the facility during that incident.

On Sunday evening, as a movie was being screened for the inmates and when the staff strength was less and preoccupied with other work, more than 10 of them allegedly escaped. They also managed to escape being noticed by the



The Government Observation Home and Place of Safety in Athur houses more than 70 juveniles and young offenders aged between 18 and 21 from across Tamil Nadu. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

According to police sources, several rival groups operate inside the institution and a violent clash broke out between two of these groups

security guard at the entrance. The group broke open the main gate to escape from the premises.

After fleeing, the escapees allegedly intercepted motorists on the Chengalpattu-Orakkattupetta Road, assaulted and robbed them of two-wheelers, mobile phones, and cash before escaping.

A preliminary investigation by the Chengalpattu Taluk Police found the ab-

sconding youths are reportedly from Chennai, Namakkal, Coimbatore, Theni, and other districts.

The police arrested one of the escapees during the early hours of Monday. Investigators said he had allegedly reached his residence around midnight in an intoxicated condition after escaping from the observation home.

Acting on information, the police arrested him from his house and brought him to the Chengalpattu Taluk Police Station for questioning.

Probe on

The police are continuing their investigation to trace the remaining 11 inmates who escaped.

Vijay inaugurates MLA office in Perambur constituency, app for grievance redress

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay inaugurated the Member of Legislative Assembly's (MLA) office in his constituency, Perambur, on Monday. He also distributed new smart ration cards to beneficiaries in the area.

The President of Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam (TVK), Mr. Vijay, who contested and won from two constituencies—Perambur and Tiruchi East—in the 2026 Assembly elections, retained Perambur and re-signed from his position as the MLA for Tiruchi East. Two months after the election results were declared, Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay officially visited the Perambur constituency for the first time on Monday.

The Chief Minister inaugurated the renovated MLA office in Sharma Nagar. Minister for Public Works and Sports Development Aadhav Arjuna was present at the event.

Minister for Revenue and Disaster Management K.A. Sengottaiyan, Minister for Food and Civil Supplies P. Venkataramanan, and Minister for Transport A. Vijay Tamilan Parthiban welcomed the Chief Minister. Afterwards, he enquired about the facilities available at the MLA office. Appropriate certificates were also issued to five individuals who had applied for various services.

He then inaugurated the e-Sevai centre located within the premises. Fol-



Warm welcome: Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay during his visit to the Perambur Assembly constituency to open the MLA's office on Monday. B. JOTHI RAMALINGAM

lowing this, he received grievance petitions from the general public.

Later, the Chief Minister walked along the side street, accepting flower bouquets presented by the public. Walking a short distance from his office, the Chief Minister reached a nearby ration shop and distributed smart family cards to several beneficiaries. He also distributed food grains to a few individuals.

After this, he inspected the Metropolitan Transport Corporation's (MTC) electric bus depot in Vyasarpadi, even boarding a few buses to conduct inspections.

A website, tvkcm.com, and a mobile application were launched for the residents of Perambur to report their grievances.

Civic projects

The State government has planned to implement new civic infrastructure projects for development of Perambur Assembly Constituency, estimated at

₹1,013 crore in the next two years. As many as 50 projects, will be implemented in the next two years in Perambur.

The Chief Minister, on Monday, also approved seven projects under the MLA Local Area Development Scheme, including a sports facility in Mayor Krishnamurthy Nagar in ward 45, a cricket pitch and basketball court in Dr. Ambedkar Arts and Science College, dialysis centre in ward 45, gig workers' facility in ward 35, bus shelters at six locations and modernisation of anganwadis.

Chennai Corporation Commissioner G.S. Sameeran said: "Today, the Chief Minister had a brief review with officials of various departments regarding the infrastructure needs in Perambur constituency in particular and North Chennai in general. Also, the Chief Minister had immediately sanctioned his MLALAD Fund of ₹3 crore to seven different projects."

Govt. doctors' panel calls for clinical, academic posts at Egmore hospital

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The Legal Coordination Committee (LCC) for Government Doctors has urged the State government to create dedicated academic and clinical posts at the Assisted Reproductive Technology centre at the Institute of Obstetrics and Gynaecology and Hospital for Women and Children, Egmore.

In a statement issued, LCC said the government

has not sanctioned dedicated permanent posts for this specialised unit. It requested immediate creation of one post of professor and associate professor each, and two assistant professors to sustain this facility.

While welcoming the administrative speed in providing government employment orders to the kin of Karur stampede victims within 60 days of assuming office, LCC said in stark contrast, the family of Vi-

vekanandan, a government doctor who died during COVID-19, has been running from pillar to post for over five years. The association appealed to the CM to grant a government job for the doctor's wife and provide comprehensive relief.

It also called for implementation of Government Order 354 to ensure Dynamic Assured Career Progression and pay band-4 within 12 years of service for government doctors.

Rathothsavam of new golden chariot of temple held

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The grand newly completed 25-foot-tall golden chariot of the Arulmigu Ekambaranathar Temple was taken out on a procession through the Raja veezhi and mada streets of Kancheepuram town on Sunday evening.

One of the biggest golden chariots in the country -- 13 feet long and 10 feet wide -- this one carrying the idols of Sri Ekambaranathar and Sri Elavarkuzhalihamman, was dedicated



The golden chariot of the Arulmigu Ekambaranathar Temple being taken out on a procession in Kancheepuram town on Sunday.

to the temple by the pontiff of the Sankara Mutt Sri Vijayendra Saraswathi Shan-

karacharya Swamigal in December last year, coinciding with the shrine's

Ministers S. Ramesh, R.V. Ranjithkumar and K. Thennarasu were present during the occasion

kumbhabhishekam. Usually golden or silver chariots are not very tall and are taken on a procession only inside the temples.

Making of chariot

The golden chariot was first conceived by Sri Jayendra Saraswathi Shankaracharya Swamigal who blessed the commence-

ment of the making and collection of gold and its wooden frame.

Sri Vijayendra Saraswathi Swamigal, who was present during the event to launch the chariot on Sunday, a Pradhosham day, had ensured its completion.

Ministers S. Ramesh, R.V. Ranjithkumar and K. Thennarasu graced the occasion during which a performance by 108 nadaswaram and thavil vidwans, Kailasha Vadyam, and chanting of Vedas and Slokas were organised.

Timings
CHENNAI

TUESDAY, JUL. 14
RISE 05:51 SET 18:40
RISE 05:27 SET 18:50

WEDNESDAY, JUL. 15
RISE 05:51 SET 18:40
RISE 06:34 SET 19:44

THURSDAY, JUL. 16
RISE 05:51 SET 18:40
RISE 07:37 SET 20:32

Chennai Weather	max	min
Tiruvallur	38	26
Chennai Airport	39	27
Chennai City	38	27

Chennai Airport Today
39°C Weather will be dry. Day will be hot and uneasy. Night also will be uneasy.

Chennai Airport Tomorrow
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THE HINDU
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CHILDS Trust hospital opens cystic fibrosis clinic for enhanced care

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Kanchi Kamakoti CHILDS Trust Hospital (KKCTH) has launched a cystic fibrosis clinic to strengthen coordinated care for children.

According to a press release, cystic fibrosis is an inherited, progressive genetic condition that primarily affects the lungs and digestive system, although several other organs may also be involved. Traditionally considered rare in India, it is now increasingly being recognised across the country.

However, delayed diagnosis remains a major challenge, often resulting in advanced lung disease, poor growth and other complications.

Children with cystic fibrosis require regular, lifelong, multidisciplinary care. A dedicated clinic brings together specialists in paediatric pulmonology, gastroenterology, nutrition, physiotherapy, and endocrinology, along with medical social workers.

Regular follow-up helps in early detection and treatment of lung infections, close monitoring of growth and lung health, optimisation of airway clearance and nutrition, and the appropriate use of medicines, including newer targeted therapies.

The initiative will be formally inaugurated alongside a Continuing Medical Education programme on July 19.

CINEMA ♦ ARTS ♦ EVENTS

MUSIC DANCE DRAMA

Bombay Gnanam Arts Academy & Mahalakshmi Ladies Drama Group Presents

ADVAITHA MOORTHY

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14th, 15th, 16th July 2026 6.45 P.M.

Mylopore Fine Arts Club A/C

45, Musiri Subramaniam Road, Mylopore, Ch-4, (Near St. Isabel Hospital)

8939298790, 9840356632

Bharatiya Vidya Bhavan, East Mado Street, Mylopore, Chennai-4

Is conducting "Tamil Theatre Festival 2026" from 14th July 2026 to 17th July 2026 at Bhavan's Main Hall, Mylopore, Chennai-4.

Today: 14th July: High Tea at 5.30 pm, 6.00 pm: Inauguration Sri N.Ravi, Chairman, Bhavan's Chennai Kendra presides. Dr.Nallu Kuppaswami Chetti, Vice-Chairman Welcomes. Kalaimamani Kum.Sachu (Veteran actress) receives the "Iyakkumar Sigaram K.Balachander Award" (instituted by Kavithalayaa Sri T.Krishnan), 6.45 pm: UAA's "Varadu Kuty-Parithaika Neramachu-2".

Tomorrow: 15th July: ThRees "Kaatriniley Varum Geetham". All are Welcome.

Sponsored by : **Nalli**

Ramapriya Arts Foundation, Ph: 9840971562

Today 6.15 p.m. - Prasanna Venkatraman - Gayathri Shivani - Manoj Siva - Trichy Murali, Raga Sudha Hall, Mylapore, Chennai. Sponsored by SAFE.

SRMBV Ashram - 9448488831

Discourse in Tamil by PUJY-ASRI. Ramanacharana Tirtha (Nochur) Swami from 6:30 -8:30pm, 10th -16th July and morning 10am -11 am from 11th -16th July at Narada Gana Sabha (Main Hall), All are welcome.

Devi School of Dance

Arangatram of Anya Vinod (Singapore) 19th July 2026 - Krishna Gana Sabha - 4 p.m - 7 p.m. All are welcome.

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PERSONAL	PERSONAL
CHANGE OF NAME	CHANGE OF NAME

I, SUMAIYA A., Daughter of Pachamuthu, Wife of Abdullah N. (formerly known as Arumugam N.), residing at No. 20, 1st Mettu Street, Chelliamman Nagar, Durgla Nagar Main Road, Tambaram Sanatorium, Chennai-600047, was previously known as "Thavamani P. (Pachamuthu)" and "Thavamani Arumugam". I have changed my name to "Sumaiya A.". This change of name has been published in the Tamil Nadu Government Gazette No. 51, Part VI-Section 4, Page No. 2266, Advertisement No. 3925, dated 24.12.2025.

I, Arputharaj Joseph Andrew, residing at No.4, A2, Babu Street, Sambanthanagar, Pammal, Kancheepuram, 600075 have changed my name to Andrew A for all future purposes, vide affidavit dated 08-07-2026 sworn before Notary D.Jey Kumari, Chennai.

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N Kunjammal W/o V Nagasundaram R/o 34/103, Krishna street, ICF colony, Ambattur, Thiruvallur, Tamilnadu - 600058, declare that my name has been changed to Sulochana for all purposes. -Venkatasubramanian Lalitha Kumari

I, Praveena, (W/o.Mr.Mohan Ranga) aged 45years born on 12/06/1981 in Chennai, residing at F-4, 1st Flr, Anandam Flats, 156/221, MTH Road, Villuakkam, Ch-49, shall henceforth be known as PRAVEENA MOHAN.

PUBLIC NOTICE

PUBLIC NOTICE

NOTICE is hereby given to the general public that, my Client (name not disclosed) has proposed to purchase the Properties which are morefully described in the schedule hereunder, belonging to **Mr. K. KUMANAN**, S/o. Shri. Karunanithi, residing at Door No. 36, Biramanar Street, Kambarajapuram, Kancheepuram - 631 605, by virtue of the 3 (Three) Sale Deeds dated 20.11.2023, 20.11.2023 & 21.11.2023, registered as Documents bearing Nos. 7315/2023, 7316/2023 & 7317/2023 respectively, all on 21.11.2023, on the file of The Sub-Registrar Office, Kancheepuram Joint -II, Kancheepuram District.

It is hereby notified that if any person or entity has any claim, objection or right, whether legal or equitable, over the Schedule Properties, they are required to notify the undersigned with the supporting documents within **14 (Fourteen) days** (all days including) of this notice.

Failure to notify within the stipulated time frame will be considered a waiver of any claims and the transaction will proceed without further consideration of such claims.

SCHEDULE OF PROPERTY

In the Registration District of Kancheepuram, Sub - Registration District of Kancheepuram Joint - II, Kancheepuram District, Kancheepuram Taluk, **Siruvakkam Village, in Survey No. 487/3B**, land admeasuring an extent of **Wet Acre 0.36 (or) Hectare 0.14.50 (In Full)**, **Survey No. 487/4A**, land admeasuring an extent of **Wet Acre 0.04 (or) Hectare 0.01.50 (In Full) & Survey No. 487/4B**, land admeasuring an extent of **Wet Acre 0.48 (or) Hectare 0.19.50 (In Full)**, in this, excluding the land admeasuring an extent of **Wet Acre 0.06 in the North Eastern Side**, the remaining land admeasuring an extent of **Wet Acre 0.42**, totally the land admeasuring an extent of **Wet Acre 0.82**, having **Patta Nos. 3749 & 241**, with all appurtenances attached therewith along with all kinds of easements rights including ingress and egress.

I. JESUDASON, B.A., B.L., D.L.L., Advocate.

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Place: Kancheepuram Mobile No. 98422 23099

Date : 14.07.2026 Email ID: jesuangelass@gmail.com

Vairamuthu conferred Jnanpith Award

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Tamil poet and lyricist R. Vairamuthu was on Monday conferred the 60th Jnanpith Award for the year 2025.

He is the third Tamil literary figure to receive the award, after a gap of 24 years. Earlier recipients include the late writers Akilan and Jayakanthan. Mr. Vairamuthu won the Sahitya Akademi Award in 2003 for *Kallikattu Ithikasan*.

The award was presented by politician and scholar Karan Singh at a ceremony in New Delhi. As part of the honour, Mr. Vairamuthu received a cash prize of ₹11 lakh, a bronze statue of Vagdevi (Goddess Saraswati), and a citation.

Keynote address

Delivering the keynote address, Mr. Singh emphasised the continuing relevance of literature in the age of science and technology, and urged the younger generation to forge a deeper connection with Indian languages and literary traditions.

Mr. Vairamuthu dedicated the honour to the Tamil language and the wider fraternity of Indian literature. He described literature as a source of hope, compassion, and moral strength, and said the recognition would encourage him to continue his creative pursuits.

Siddha doctors' body submits demands to govt.

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The National Women Siddha Doctors' Association has urged the State government not to permit fresh admissions to the Bachelor of Naturopathy and Yogic Sciences (BNYS) course for the current academic year. The course was being offered without the required statutory recognition, the association said.

The association submitted a representation to the State government, highlighting issues concerning Siddha medicine. Following this, the association was invited to attend a meeting convened by the Secretary to Government, Health and Family Welfare Department, to discuss the demands in detail, a press release said.

During the meeting, the association placed a number of demands.

Besides seeking action regarding the BNYS course, the association said the government

should conduct a comprehensive inquiry into the MD Yoga, MD Naturopathy, and MD Acupuncture programmes, which were being offered without University Grants Commission approval, and initiate appropriate legal and regulatory action wherever necessary.

To safeguard the interests of students and the general public, the government should take appropriate action against medical courses and therapies that were being offered without the necessary statutory approvals, or in violation of applicable laws and regulations, it said.

The association said these demands were submitted with the objective of protecting the integrity of Siddha medicine and ensuring high quality standards in medical education.

It hoped that the government would take prompt and appropriate action on the issues it had raised.

**REGIONAL CANCER CENTRE**
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Period of Work :- 90 (Ninety) days
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Managing Director, OCC Ltd., Bhubaneswar OCCL-MECH/ 01 / 2026-27 11,800/- (Non-refundable) 15.07.2026 10.00 A.M. to 29.07.2026 5.00 P.M. 15.07.2026 10.00 A.M. to 29.07.2026 5.00 P.M.
Date of opening of the Technical Bid: **30.07.2026 at 11.30 A.M.**
Further details can be seen from the Govt. website (www.tendersodisha.gov.in)
Amendment/corrigendum/cancellation, if any shall be posted on-line only
Managing Director
34001/471/262Z
OIPR-34001/34120/1/26-27/0013

**South Bihar Power Distribution Co. Ltd, Patna Bihar**
Registered Office: Vidhyut Bhawan, Bailey Road, Patna-21
A Govt. of Bihar undertaking
CIN No. U40109BR2012SGCO18890
(Department of Stores & Purchase)
NOTICE INVITING TENDER
NIT No. 67/PR/SBPDCI/2026
(Through e-procurement mode only - www.eproc2.bihar.gov.in)
South Bihar Power Distribution Co. Ltd. (SBPDCL), a Government of Bihar Undertaking, invites online tender for procurement of 33 KV 3 element outdoor type oil immersed combined metering unit of CT & PT of 0.2s accuracy class for SBPDCL & NBPDCI in Two-tier (Techno-Commercial & Price) online bid from eligible and experienced Original Manufacturer as detailed below:-

Name of material	Quantity	Cost of tender Document including GST@18%, Rs	Total Estimated Cost including GST@18%,Rs	Earnest Money Deposit, Rs.
33 KV 3 element outdoor type oil immersed combined metering unit of CT & PT of 0.2s accuracy class	25/1A-70 nos. 50/1A-60 nos., 100/1A-40 nos., 200/1A-10 nos., 400/1A-05 nos., 600/1A-05 nos. Total-190 nos.	11,800/-	2,68,67,900/-	5,37,358/-

The Time line for the above tender is as follows:

Last Date of Online Submission of bid along with Tender Cost & processing fees:	17.08.2026, up to 18:00 Hrs
Last Date of submission of EMD and hard copy of receipt of BSEDCL processing fee & tender cost	18.08.2026, up to 15:00 Hrs
Date of opening of Techno-Commercial bid(Part-I)	18.08.2026, after 17:00 Hrs
Date of Pre Bid Meeting:	28.07.2026, at 15:00 Hrs; Venue: SBPDCL, Vidyut Bhawan-3, Patna

BSEDCL(BELTRON) Processing fee & tender cost are mandatory to be paid through online mode i.e. Internet Payment gateway (credit / debit card), net banking, NEFT/RTGS. Bids along with necessary online payments must be submitted through e-payment portal www.eproc2.bihar.gov.in before the date and time specified in the NIT. EMD in prescribed format and hard copy of receipt of BSEDCL processing fee & tender cost must be submitted to Electrical Superintending Engineer (Purchase), SBPDCL within specified time failing which bid of the firm shall be summarily rejected. The department does not take any responsibility for the delay / Non submission of Tender / Non Reconciliation of online Payment caused due to Non-availability of Internet Connection, Network Traffic/ Holidays or any other reason. **Date of opening of price part: To be notified after Technical Bid Evaluation at** www.eproc2.bihar.gov.in

e-tendering introduced in SBPDCL for tenders above Rs. 25 lacs.
For registration login to www.eproc2.bihar.gov.in and Eproc2 Helpdesk Details: Toll Free Number 1800 572 6571, Email Id: eproc2support@bihar.gov.in, Working Hours: 8AM to 7PM (All days in week except few selected state holidays).
While participating in e-tendering process, the contractor shall have to get them registered to get user ID, Passwords and digital signature. This will enable them to access the Website: www.eproc2.bihar.gov.in only

For complaints regarding corruption Vigilance Help Line No.- 9431821485, 0612-2504969.
Consumer can deposit electricity bills via Sahaz Vasudha Centre or <http://bills.sbpdcil.in/>

Note:- Subsequent information/notification/corrigendum will be available only on website of EPROC and/or SBPDCL i.e. www.eproc2.bihar.gov.in and/or www.sbpdcil.co.in.
For further details please visit website state.bihar.gov.in/prdbihar
PR- 007652 (B & C) 2026-27
नशे की मार, बर्बाद कर सुखी परिवार।
Electrical Superintending Engineer (Purchase)

**THE HINDU**
Air Surcharge as applicable:
New Delhi - Rs. 15/-
Port Blair - Rs. 20/-

**EAST CENTRAL RAILWAY**
E-TENDER NOTICE
No. ECR-CAO-C-S-ETEN-DOS-08
e-tender is invited on behalf of the President of India for the under mentioned work:-
SN. 1, e-Tender No. : ECR-CAO-C-S-ETEN-DOS-08 in Two packet system, Name of work: Construction of New B.G. Line between FOC for DDU Bypass Line (2.666 Km), Approx cost of the work (in Rs.): 11,57,52,672.80, Bid Security: 23,15,100.00, Period of work completion: 06 (Six) Months, Date and time for closing of tender: 30.07.2026 at 15.00 hrs.
Any e-tenders which is sent by Post/Courier/Fax or by hand will not be accepted. All such manual submission of tender even if it is on firm's letter pad or received in time will not be accepted. The above e-tender document alongwith full information is available on website www.irops.gov.in.
Note: In case of any discrepancies found in tender notice, English version will be final. Tenderers are requested to visit the website <http://www.irops.gov.in> at least 15 days before last date of closing, for latest corrigendum/corrections etc in connection with this e-tender.
Dy.CEE/Con
EC Rly, Delhi-on-Son
PR/0537/CONSTRUCTION DOS/CONST/17/26-27/40

**EAST CENTRAL RAILWAY**
OPEN E - TENDER NOTICE
E-Tender notice no. : ECR-SNT-07/27/26-27
Sealed tenders are invited for and on behalf of president of India from competent and experienced contractors for execution of the work mentioned below- S.N. (i) Name of work with its location and Completion Period: Appointment of Project Supervision Services Agency (PSSA) for providing Project Supervision Services at various Project Sites/Sections in the work jurisdiction of Chief Signal, & Telecom Engineer/Work, East Central Railway, Hajipur. Completion period 24 months (ii) Approx. cost of the work : Rs.12,40,44,578 (Rupees Twelve Crore Forty Lakh Forty Four Thousand Five Hundred Seventy Eight only). (iii) Earnest Money to be deposited : 7,70,200/- (iv) Last date and time of submission of tender and Opening of tender : 11/09/2026 up to 15.30 Hrs. and 11/09/2026 at 16.00 Hrs. (v) Website particulars, Notice Board Location where complete details of tender can be seen. : www.irops.gov.in, on the Notice Board of Principal Chief Signal & Telecom Engineer/East Central Railway/Hajipur & Dy. Chief Signal & Telecommunication Engineer/Work-II, East Central Railway/Hajipur. **PR/0538/HQ/S&T/T/26-27/40**

**EAST CENTRAL RAILWAY**
OPEN E-TENDER NOTICE
NO. SEE26-27-(82, 90 & 92)
The DRM (Engg.)/SEE for and on behalf of the President of India invites Open E-Tenders for the following works. The last date of online E-tendering is 31.07.2026 upto 13:00 hrs. All information and tender documents related to E-tender is available on website - www.irops.gov.in.
Name of Works: 82. Sonpur Division - TTR 60 Kg 1 in 12 (FS + TWS + WCMSC) - 87 sets & TTR (TWS + WCMSC) - 6 SETS AND Glued Joints - 176 Nos., Approx Cost (In Rs.): 1,79,16,033.02, Earnest Money (In Rs.): 3,58,300.00
Name of Works: 90. Umesh Nagar - Yard remodelling work for extension of CSL of lines at UMNRR Station, Approx Cost (In Rs.): 1,16,87,868.02, Earnest Money (In Rs.): 2,33,800.00
Name of Works: 92. Danaula/ Phulwaria - Yard remodelling work for extension of CSL of lines at DPL Station, Approx Cost (In Rs.): 01,97,37,496.79, Earnest Money (In Rs.): 3,94,800.00
The above tender notice is available on website www.irops.gov.in, TENDER: RAILWAY TO DEAL WITH TENDER: Railway Administration reserves the right to postpone/modify or to cancel any one or all the tenders without assigning any reasons.
Divisional Railway Manager/Engg., Sonpur
PR/0529/SEE/ENGG/T/26-27/44

**EAST CENTRAL RAILWAY**
E-Open Tender Notice
E-Tender notice no.: TL-AC-CRW-HRT-DUCT-5, Date: 08.07.2026
For and on behalf of President of India, Dy. Chief Mechanical Engineer, Carriage Repair Workshop, Harnaut invites open e-tender for the following works as detailed:-
1. Name of work with its location : Replacement of bellow duct with Meta Aramide Fabric Bellow Duct in 507 LHB coaches at CRW/HRT. 2. Approx. cost of the work: Rs. 5,56,94,467.14 (Rupees Five Crore Fifty Six Lakh Ninety Four Thousand Four Hundred Sixty Seven and Paise Fourteen Only). 3. Cost of Tender Form : Nil. 4. Bid Security to be deposited : Rs. 11,13,900.00 (Rupees Eleven Lakh Thirteen Thousand Nine Hundred Only). 5. Date & Time for submission of tender and opening of Tender : The tender have to be submitted online on <https://www.irops.gov.in> website up to 12:00 hrs. on 29.07.2026 and will be opened on the same day at 12:30 hrs., 6. Website particulars, Notice board location where complete details of tender can be seen and address of the office from where the tender form can be purchased etc. : Detailed tender notice, eligibility criteria & tender documents can be seen from the CRIS website: <https://www.irops.gov.in> & full details of notice can be seen on notice board in the office of Chief Workshop Manager, Administrative Building, Carriage Repair Workshop, Harnaut, Nalanda and Bihar - 803110. All corrigendum will be uploaded on website if required.
Dy. Chief Mechanical Engineer
Carriage Repair Workshop/Harnaut
PR/545/CRW-HRT/Mech./T/26-27/48

**THE HINDU**
Your feedback will keep us Cleaner, Sharper and Bolder
Call our toll-free number
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Or write to us at
customercare@thehindu.co.in
Scan the QR code to register your feedback
THE HINDU thehindu businessline.
FRONTLINE SPORTSTAR THE HINDU Young World THE HINDU

**EAST CENTRAL RAILWAY**
COPY OF E-TENDER NOTICE FOR DIFFERENT ELECTRICAL WORKS OPEN TENDER FOR ELECTRICAL (TRD)
DRM (Electrical) / TRD / ECR / Dhanbad for and behalf of the President of India invites e-tender for execution of the work indicated as under.
E-Tender No.: TRD-OT-07-CYBER-SEC-26-27
SI. No. 01. Name of work with location and Completion of work: Upgradation of TSS/SP/SSP RTUs due to implementation of Cyber Security in SCADA system for HZBN-TIS, KQR-HZBN & KQR-NGRH section, Completion period (12) (Twelve Months), 02. Approx cost of the work: Rs. 2,50,66,000/- (Cost of e-tender form-Nil), 03. Bid Security to be deposited: Rs. 5,01,300/-, 04. Date & Time for submission of closing and opening of E-Tender: Closing of E-Tender- On 31.07.2026 at 11:00 hrs., Opening of E-Tender- On 31.07.2026 at 11:30 hrs., 05. Website particulars: **W e b s i t e : www.irops.gov.in**
Manual tender offer not accepted under e-tender.
Divl. Railway Manager (Elect.) / TRD
East Central Railway, Dhanbad
PR/0532/DHN/TRD/T/26-27/36

**S. E. RAILWAY - TENDER**
Tender Notice No. (i) DRMENGGRNC-53-2026, (ii) DRMENGGRNC-54-2026 & (iii) DRMENGGRNC-55-2026, Divisional Railway Manager (Engg), S.E. Railway, Ranchi for & on behalf of the President of India invites E-Tenders for the following work. SI. No., Notice No. & Name of work are as follows :
1. DRMENGGRNC-53-2026. Execution of work for Flash Butt Welding for 60 kg/60EI-R-260 rails in the jurisdiction of Sr. DEN(South)/RNC. Tender Value : ₹ 1,27,32,972/-, EMD Value : ₹ 2,54,700/-, 2. DRMENGGRNC-54-2026. Execution of work for Flash Butt Welding for 60 kg/60EI-R-260 rails in different location in Ranchi Division. Tender Value : ₹ 1,45,51,968/-, EMD Value : ₹ 2,91,000/-, 3. DRMENGGRNC-55-2026. Execution of work for Flash Butt Welding for 60 kg/60EI-R-260 rails in the jurisdiction of DEN(East)/RNC. Tender Value : ₹ 2,52,84,044.40, EMD Value : ₹ 5,05,700/-, Tender Closing date & time: 07.08.2026 at 15.00 hrs. for each. Tenderers can visit the website www.irops.gov.in for online tendering. (PR-471)

**MSME TECHNOLOGY CENTRE**
2 DAYS GOVERNMENT CERTIFICATE PROGRAM ON
INCOME TAX PRACTITIONER
Course Duration (ONLINE) Date: 18 & 19 July 2026
2 Days Time: 5:00 PM to 8:30 PM
Course Content: INCOME TAX RETURN FILING PROCESS, Slab Rates of Income tax-Heads of Income, Income from Salary, Deductions from Salary, Clubbing of Income, Income from House Property, Home Loan Interest Deduction, Income from Business / Profession, Concept of Depreciation, Income from Capital Gains, Income from Other Sources Set off / Carry forward of losses, Deductions from Income (80C, 80D etc.), Forms for ITR, TDS RETURN FILING & TDS provisions More Topics
Fees : Rs.3,000/- (Study material in soft copy shall be provided)
Coordinator: 9818676812, 9818528498, 9868564246
Government of India certificate will be awarded

**Ministry of Micro, Small & Medium Enterprises**
MSME - TECHNOLOGY DEVELOPMENT CENTRE - (CGI)
An Autonomous body under Ministry of MSME, Govt. of India
2 DAYS GOVERNMENT TRAINING ON
GEM REGISTRATION E-MARKETING, Contracts & E-Tender
Start your Business with Government E-Marketplace
Course Duration (ONLINE) Date: 18 & 19 July 2026
2 Days Time: 5:00 PM to 8:30 PM
Course Content: Introduction of Government e-Marketplace, Product uploading, Services uploading, Bid participate, Direct purchase through a link, What is L1 Comparison & direct purchase, Seller Profile (GST ITR & Udyam), technically error solution, Multi order in one cart, Tax assessment, What is vendors assessment & process, BOM portal introduction, New Product Category Apply (what is a process), Product / Services Registration with Golden Parameter (Brand Registration), How to Manage Bid, Payment Processing, How to Supply your product or services in government sector, Note:
Fees : Rs.3,000/- (Study material in soft copy shall be provided)
FREE PAYMENT ONLY IN MSME TDC CGI ACCOUNT
Coordinator: 8603769900, 9953820498, 8168984069
Government of India certificate will be awarded

**SEARCH COMMITTEE FOR THE APPOINTMENT OF STATE CHIEF INFORMATION COMMISSIONER AND FOUR STATE CHIEF INFORMATION COMMISSIONERS OF TAMIL NADU INFORMATION COMMISSION**

Applications are invited for the posts of State Chief Information Commissioner and four State Information Commissioners for the Tamil Nadu Information Commission. Interested persons may send their application in the prescribed form along with the relevant documents by Speed Post / Registered Post and also by e-Mail so as to reach the following address on or before 5.00 pm on 04.08.2026.
Hon'ble Thiru. Justice R.S. Ramanathan, Retired High Court Judge, Chairperson, Search Committee,
"Parijatham", Old No. 4B2, New No.15, Rajagopalnagar Street, Valmiki Nagar, Thiruvanniyur, Chennai - 600 041. Email ID: searchcommittee2026@gmail.com
Application form and other details can be downloaded from www.tn.gov.in/job_opportunity.php.
DIPR/618/Display/2026 **CHAIRPERSON, SEARCH COMMITTEE**

**Tamil Nadu Public Service Commission**
Chennai - 600 003.

Advertisement No.738/2026 Dated: 13.07.2026
TENDER NOTICE
Tenders in the prescribed format are invited from the potential, experienced and eligible reputed firms for Open Tender for Conducting Computer Based Test (CBT) of Examinations for Departmental and Direct Recruitment Examinations conducted by the Tamil Nadu Public Service Commission (TNPSC), Chennai for a period of two years.
Tender Document with detailed specifications of terms and conditions, Technical Bid and BOQ can be downloaded from the websites <http://tntenders.gov.in> or www.tnpsc.gov.in
For any queries related to the Bid Submission, bidders shall contact by email: menaga1210@tn.gov.in
DIPR/2271/TENDER/2026 **Controller of Examinations**

**कर्मचारी राज्य बीमा निगम**
Employees' State Insurance Corporation

“ Our government is committed to the development of a generous and comprehensive social security mechanism for all workers. ”
Narendra Modi
Prime Minister

Strengthening Healthcare for Workforce Across the Nation

Inauguration of

New OPD Block, ESIC Hospital, Sanathnagar, Telangana

and

Virtual Inauguration of

100 Bedded ESIC Hospital, Sripurumbudur, Tamil Nadu

100 Bedded ESIS Hospital, Rajamahendravaram, Andhra Pradesh

Upgraded 200 Bedded ESIC Hospital, Beltola, Guwahati, Assam

ESI Dispensary and Branch Office, Kota, Rajasthan

ESI Dispensary, Bhawanimandi, Rajasthan

ESI Dispensary and Branch Office, Surendranagar, Gujarat

By
Dr. Mansukh Mandaviya
Minister of Labour & Employment and Youth Affairs & Sports, Government of India

Tuesday, 14th July, 2026 | ESIC Hospital, Sanathnagar, Telangana

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INBRIEF



Counselling for engineering admission commences in T.N.

The Tamil Nadu Engineering Admissions (TNEA) 2026 counselling process got under way on Monday as the TNEA committee enabled the choice-filling option for the special reservation categories under the horizontal reservation for students who studied in government schools from Classes VI to XII (7.5% reservation scheme). The special reservation categories pertained to persons with disabilities, sports quota, and wards of ex-servicemen, a TNEA release said.

A. Arun shifted from DVAC to Tamil Nadu Police Academy

The Tamil Nadu Government on Monday transferred Additional Director General of Police (ADGP) A. Arun from the post of Director of the Directorate of Vigilance and Anti-Corruption (DVAC). He is now ADGP/Director of the Tamil Nadu Police Academy in Oonamancherry. Mr. Arun served as the Greater Chennai Police Commissioner from July 2024 to April 2026 and was transferred on the directions of the Election Commission. After the TVK-led coalition government, headed by Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay, assumed office, he was appointed Director of the DVAC on May 25. He has now been transferred within two months of taking charge. Inspector General of Police C. Mageshwari has been given additional charge as the Director of the DVAC.

ED receives copies of documents in alleged ‘horse-trading’ case

The agency is likely to probe the money laundering angle in the case. The police had seized ₹60 lakh in unaccounted cash from one of the suspects

S. Vijay Kumar
CHENNAI

The Directorate of Enforcement (ED) has taken a copy of documents relating to the alleged ₹35-crore MLA “horse-trading” case from the Greater Chennai Police (GCP), official sources said on Monday.

The case pertains to the complaint lodged by Uthangarai MLA N. Elaiyaraja of the ruling Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam (TVK) claiming that one Thirunavukkarasu, identifying himself as the owner of Indian Political Democratic Strategies (IDPS), a firm involved in conducting surveys, contacted him to support a proposed no-confidence motion against the Speaker and also offered a bribe of ₹35 crore.

The MLA lodged a complaint with the city police against Thirunavukkarasu for attempting to bribe and threaten him. A special team of the Triplicane police arrested Thirunavukkarasu and his associates – Naresh of Tiruchi and



Uthangarai MLA N. Elaiyaraja, on whose complaint the case was registered.

Inquires revealed that the accused tried to bribe the MLA at the behest of V. Senthilbalaji and his brother V. Ashok Kumar

Thiagarajan of Medavakam in Chennai.

Investigators seized about ₹60 lakh in unaccounted cash from the premises of one of the suspects in the case. There was evidence for suspecting a hawala transaction, the sources said.

According to the police, during the course of inves-

tigation it came to light that one of the suspects, Naresh, had met V. Ashok Kumar, brother of former Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (DMK) Minister and Coimbatore (South) MLA V. Senthilbalaji in Chennai.

Sources added that further inquiries revealed Thirunavukkarasu had tried to bribe the MLA at the behest of Mr. Senthilbalaji and his brother.

The case was construed to be an attempt to destabilise the ruling party in the State, even as both the TVK and the DMK levelled horse-trading allegations against each other.

ED officials wrote to Greater Chennai Police Commissioner A. Amalraj, requesting a copy of the documents relating to the case. “We have given a set of case documents to the ED on their request,” a senior police officer told *The Hindu*.

The Madras High Court on July 8, 2026, granted conditional anticipatory bail to Mr. Senthilbalaji and Mr. Ashok Kumar in the case.

6 persons killed, 40 injured as buses collide in Madurai

The Hindu Bureau
MADURAI

Six persons, including five passengers of two buses, were killed after a Marthandam-bound omnibus collided with a TNSTC bus proceeding to Tiruchi, near Karungalakudi on Madurai-Tiruchi Highway in Madurai district on Monday.

Forty passengers and crew members of both buses were injured. They were taken to the Government Hospital at Melur, the Government Rajaji Hospital (GRH), and a private hospital in Madurai.

The police said the omnibus driver lost control of the vehicle, which swerved to the right at Vanjinagaram near Karungalakudi around 3.30 a.m. The bus jumped over the median and rammed against the TNSTC bus coming on the opposite lane. In the impact, the TNSTC bus overturned.

Within a few seconds, the omnibus swerved to the left and jumped the median again, Madurai District Superintendent of Police N. Devanathan said. It came to a halt only after hitting the concrete bus shelter on the left side of the four-lane highway.

Three passengers of the TNSTC bus were killed on



Rescue effort: Firemen trying to bring trapped passengers out of the wreckage along Madurai-Tiruchi National Highway. PTI

the spot. They were identified as P. Anantharaj, 46, of Tiruchi; K. Mohammed Yasin, 60, of Tiruvavur; and G. Surya, 29, of Tiruchi. Two passengers of the omnibus were also killed. They were J. Sriyapushpam, 56, of Tirunelveli and J. Abraham, a crew member of the bus from Thiruvannamalai in Tirunelveli district.

Senior police officers and firemen rushed to the spot and started a rescue operation.

C. Perumal, 70, of Vanjinagaram, who was sleeping in the bus shelter, sustained a head injury. He was admitted to the GRH where he died later.

While others were treated as outpatients at different hospitals, a total of 19 victims were admitted to hospital. A girl from Tiruchi suffered a fracture on

the shoulder, and many of them have suffered head injuries.

The Madurai district police are investigating. Madurai Collector Nishanth Krishna, MP Su. Venkatesan, and others visited the hospitals and inquired with the doctors about the treatment being given to the injured persons.

CM announces solatium Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay has announced ex gratia of ₹3 lakh each to the families of those killed in the accident. In a press release, he said those who sustained grievous injuries would receive ₹1 lakh each, while those with minor injuries would be given ₹50,000 each. “I have directed officials to ensure that the injured receive the best possible medical treatment,” he said.

DMK to approach SC if Governor fails to take action on allegations of ‘horse-trading’ against TVK

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

DMK organising secretary R.S. Bharathi said on Monday that if Governor Rajendra Viswanath Arlekar failed to act on the party’s complaint alleging ‘horse-trading’ of MLAs by the ruling Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam (TVK), the Dravidian major would approach the Supreme Court.

Speaking to reporters after submitting a petition to the Governor in Chennai, Mr. Bharathi said the DMK had already submitted a representation on July 4, drawing the Governor’s attention to MDMK general secretary Vaiko’s claim that



R.S. Bharathi

two of his party’s MLAs (who were elected on the DMK’s symbol) had been approached by the ruling TVK with an offer to resign their Assembly membership and switch allegiance on the promise that they would be re-nominated in their respective constituencies.

He further contended

former Minister M.R. Vijayabhaskar (AIADMK) had publicly stated that he resigned his Assembly seat at the request of the ruling TVK. “These are pieces of evidence that support our allegation of horse-trading by the ruling party. We reiterated these points during our meeting with the Governor,” he said.

Alleging that Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay had used coarse language during his visit to Karur, Mr. Bharathi said Mr. Vijay had inducted former Ministers C. Vijayabaskar and Mr. Vijayabhaskar into the TVK, who the AIADMK had earlier described as “leftover leaves after a feast.”

Sahitya Akademi awardee Poomani passes away

B. Kolappan
CHENNAI

Sahitya Akademi Award-winning Tamil writer Poomani, one of the most celebrated chroniclers of the *karisal bhoomi* – the rain-fed black-soil tracts of southern Tamil Nadu – died after a prolonged illness on Sunday night in Chennai. He was 79. He is survived by his wife, two sons and a daughter.

Born Manickavasagam in Andipatti near Kovilpatti, Poomani adopted his pen name early in his literary career. An employee of the Cooperative Department, he began writing for magazines such as Thamarai before emerging as one of the most distinctive voices in modern Tamil literature. His fiction portrayed with remarkable realism

and empathy the lives, struggles and aspirations of the people of the *karisal* region, particularly in present-day Virudhunagar district.

Poomani received the Sahitya Akademi Award in 2014 for his monumental novel *Agnadi*, an epic narrative set against the backdrop of the Sivakasi (1899) and Kazhugumalai (1895) communal riots.

Poomani’s literary career spanned several decades, during which he produced a remarkable body of work, including the novels *Piragu*, *Vekkai*, *Neivedhyam*, *Kommai*, *Vaik-kaal*, and *Agnadi*, besides acclaimed short-story collections such as *Kizhisal*. *Vekkai* was adapted into the National Award-winning film *Asuran* by director Vetrimaaran, starring



Poomani

Dhanush in the lead role.

Foray into film-making

Beyond literature, Poomani also ventured into film-making. “He directed *Karuvellam Pookal* for the National Film Development Corporation (NFDC), portraying the lives of children and women employed in match factories. His television serial *Penakkal* focused on workers in the pen-nib manufacturing in-

dustry,” recalled fellow Sahitya Akademi Award-winning writer and his nephew, Cho. Dharman.

Following the release of *Asuran*, Poomani had told *The Hindu* that while he appreciated the adaptation, he did not agree with interpretations that reduced the story to a narrative of Scheduled Caste triumph over oppression. “Even though I am the author, I cannot expect every aspect of the novel to be reflected in the film. That is impossible in any adaptation. I do not know what the director had in mind while making the film. But there are some basic elements that cannot be altered,” he said.

In fact, Poomani did not want himself to be confined to the narrow identity of a “Dalit” writer.

Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay, expressing grief over the writer’s demise, announced that Poomani would be accorded state honours. In his condolence message, the Chief Minister said Poomani had enriched Tamil literature by portraying with extraordinary realism the people of the *karisal bhoomi* and the many nuances of their lives. Referring to *Asuran*, the acclaimed film adaptation of Poomani’s novel *Vekkai*, he noted the film had taken the writer’s powerful literary voice to a much wider audience.

Paying tribute, CPI(M) MP and Sahitya Akademi Award-winning writer Su. Venkatesan said Poomani viewed history through the prism of the suffering of ordinary people and their anger.

Why DISCOM privatisation is not needed in T.N.

T. Ramakrishnan
CHENNAI

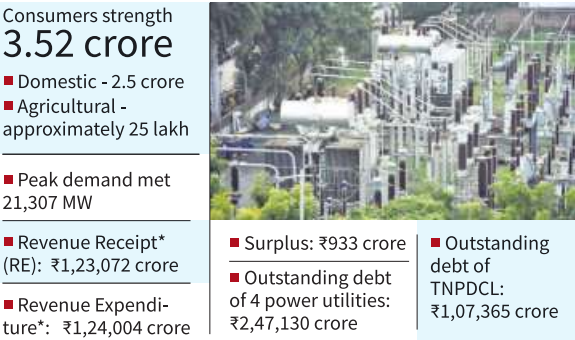
A recent assertion by Tamil Nadu Minister for Energy Resources R. Nirmalkumar that electricity distribution would not be privatised in the State is not only a policy statement but also a reiteration of the finding of a study commissioned by the 16th Finance Commission on the financial performance of electricity distribution companies (DISCOM).

Carried out by Prayas, a Pune-based non-governmental and non-profit body, the study states that “privatisation can improve operational efficiency and may be relevant in DISCOMs with unmanageably high AT&C [Aggregate Technical and Commercial] losses. However, it may not lead to major benefits” in States such as Tamil Nadu, where “AT&C losses are low and supply and service quality is relatively good,” the study observes.

As per the 14th edition of the Power Finance Corporation (PFC)’s Integrated Rating and Ranking of Pow-

Power scenario

A brief overview of Tamil Nadu’s electricity sector



* 2025-26, RE - Revised estimate
TNPDC - Tamil Nadu Power Distribution Corporation Limited

er Distribution Utilities across the country, Tamil Nadu’s AT &C losses were 10.92% for 2022-23; 11.39% for 2023-24 and 10.96% for 2024-25 against the all-India average figures of 15.22%, 15.97% and 15.04% respectively. According to the Consumer Service Ratings of the DISCOMs prepared by the REC [formerly Rural Electrification Corporation], the Tamil Nadu Power Distribution Corporation’s score with regard to distribution transformer (DT) failure rate, an indicator of supply

and service quality, was 2.65% for 2024-25 against the national average of 5.02%. There are about 4.48 lakh DTs in the State. The reports of the PFC and the REC were released early this year.

Besides the two performance parameters, the issue of privatisation, even if it is considered independent of the government’s stand against such a course of action, raises the question whether private players would be keen on taking the load of about 24 lakh agricultural connec-

tions, a substantial portion of which is in the Cauvery delta, or serving hilly areas such as the Jawadhu Hills. Invariably, the answer would be an emphatic “no” as the private firms would like to bag the plum segment of consumers. This would leave the government to wonder why it should embark on privatisation as the move would only financially weaken the power DISCOM.

Despite the REC’s push over 15 years ago, Tamil Nadu did not agree to let franchisees run rural power supply. Till about the late 1990s, a few electricity cooperative societies were functioning in areas such as Thirumayam and Kumbakonam and they were later merged with the now-abolished Tamil Nadu Electricity Board (TNEB). Successive governments have not been receptive even to creating regional power distribution companies.

But, the key problem with the TNPDC or its predecessors has been the gap between the Average Cost of Supply and the Average Revenue Realised. Of

late, the gap has gone down substantially, turning positive (₹+0.04/unit) on a provisional basis during 2025-26. “However, the gap’s narrowing is not owing to the operational efficiency or full recovery of the cost of supply from consumers,” the State government’s White Paper says, attributing the reduction to huge loss funding support given by the State government pursuant to the conditions imposed by the Union government. The prescription suggested in the document is a “comprehensive resolution framework” – covering tariff path, subsidy rationalisation, debt restructuring, and operational reform.

As hinted in the study commissioned by the Finance Commission, the problems such as cost-reflective pricing, regulatory certainty and performance accountability should be addressed effectively instead of merely going in for privatisation in Tamil Nadu which has relatively low AT&C losses and good supply quality. Else, financial stress within the system will get only redistributed.

No caste, communal, or political activities will be allowed in T.N. schools, State govt. tells court

Mohamed Imranullah S.
CHENNAI

The Directorate of School Education issued a circular on Friday making it clear that the premises of 57,671 schools functioning under it in Tamil Nadu must strictly be used only for curricular and co-curricular activities and not for any kind of caste, communal or political activities, Advocate-General Vijay Narayan told the Madras High Court on Monday.

The submission was made before the First Bench of Chief Justice Sushrut Arvind Dharmadhikari and Justice G. Arul Murugan who dismissed as withdrawn a public interest litigation petition filed by AIADMK former MLA V.P.B. Paramasivam accusing the ruling TVK of using educational institutions for political propaganda. The petitioner chose to withdraw the case in view of the latest circular.

Submitting a copy of the

circular before the Division Bench, the A-G said the Director of Private Schools, the Director of Elementary Education, and the Director of School Education had signed the circular jointly pursuant to complaints received about certain individuals using school campuses for religious, political and caste activities in an attempt to disrupt the aim of school education.

The circular said the primary aim of the School Education Department was to inculcate unity and brotherhood in 1,03,98,748 students hailing from diverse backgrounds but pursuing education together at the 57,671 schools. All the district-level school education officials were reminded that the students should never get to feel any kind of discrimination on the grounds of caste, community or political affiliation.

The Chief Educational Officers (CEOs) as well as

the District Educational Officers (DEOs) were also told that the use of school premises for caste, community or political activities would not only lead to an undesirable division among students but would also subject the young minds to psychological pressure. Therefore, the CEOs and the DEOs were instructed to convey the message to the school principals as well as the headmasters.

The circular required the principals and headmasters to ensure that their school premises remained a pleasant place, where the educational aspirations of students were fulfilled, and they were never used for non-educational activities. The heads were also asked not to allow classrooms, auditoriums, or playgrounds for activities organised by outsiders and permit only government-authorised birthday/birth anniversary celebrations of leaders.

SC rejects professor’s anticipatory bail plea in suicide case

Aaratrika Bhaumik
NEW DELHI

The Supreme Court on Monday rejected the anticipatory bail plea of a Kerala college teacher accused of abetting the suicide of a dental student, observing that such “inhuman conduct” deserved to be dealt with sternly.

“The message has to go that you cannot behave in this way with students... ‘Inhuman’ is the only word that comes to mind. How does he address the students?” a Bench of Justices Vikram Nath and Sandeep Mehta remarked while refusing anticipatory bail to M.K. Ram, former head of the Department of Dental Anatomy at Anjarakandy Dental College.

Nithin Raj, a first year BDS student at the Kannur Medical College, Anjarakandy, was found dead on the campus on April 10 in a suspected case of suicide. His family and several students alleged that he had taken the extreme step after harassment by Mr. Ram and another faculty member, Sangeetha Nambiar.

Appearing for Mr. Ram, senior advocate D.S. Naidu said the alleged incident of humiliation had occurred nearly a month before the student’s death and was too remote in time to constitute the offence of abetment. He also said that Nithin had also harassed by loan recovery agents over an unpaid loan.

(Those in distress can dial tele MANAS 14416)

SC seeks Revanna’s response on Karnataka govt. petition

State moves SC after High Court absolves JD(S) MLA of charge of use for force to outrage modesty of a woman; how can HC change charges after trial court has taken cognisance of offence, asks SC

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Supreme Court on Monday agreed to examine a plea filed by the Karnataka Government challenging a High Court order quashing the charge of assault or use of criminal force to outrage the modesty of a woman, against Janata Dal (Secular) legislator and former Karnataka Minister H.D. Revanna.

A Bench of Justices J.B. Pardiwala and K. Vinod Chandran issued notice on the State government’s appeal and called upon Mr. Revanna to file his response.

Mr. Revanna is accused of sexually harassing a former house help. The



The Bench has questioned the State government for its delay in challenging the HC order against H.D. Revanna. SUDHAKARA JAIN

complaint also alleged that his son, former JD(S) MP Prajwal Revanna, had sexually harassed the woman, following which a first information report (FIR) was registered in April 2024.

In an order on November 19, 2025 the High Court

upheld the charge of sexual harassment under Section 354A of the Indian Penal Code against Mr. Revanna but quashed the charge under Section 354 (use of criminal force the intent to outrage modesty). It had also directed the

trial court to consider afresh whether the delay of nearly three years in filing the complaint could be condoned before taking cognisance of the offence under Section 354A.

On Monday, the top court expressed reservations over the High Court’s interference after the trial court had already taken cognisance of the offence. “How can the High Court change the charges?” the Bench remarked.

The Bench also questioned the Karnataka Government over the delay in challenging the High Court’s order.

Mr. Revanna is the son of former Prime Minister H.D. Deve Gowda and the elder brother of Union Minister H.D. Kumaraswamy.

Kerala HC allows BJP councillor to take oath from prison

The Hindu Bureau
KOCHI

The Kerala High Court on Monday allowed R. Sugathan, a BJP councillor in the Thiruvananthapuram Corporation, who is under a six-month preventive detention under the Kerala Anti-Social Activities (Prevention) Act, to take his oath of office inside the Vyyur Central Prison on Tuesday.

The oath-taking is to be arranged by the Superintendent of Vyyur Central Prison and administered by the Mayor of Thiruvananthapuram at 11 a.m.

Violation of norms

Mr. Sugathan was among the 20 BJP councillors directed by the High Court to retake oath after they had violated procedure during the original ceremony by taking oath in the names of local deities. Nineteen councillors retook oath, but Mr. Sugathan, who was detained, could not attend the ceremony.

Mr. Sugathan is named in 19 criminal cases.

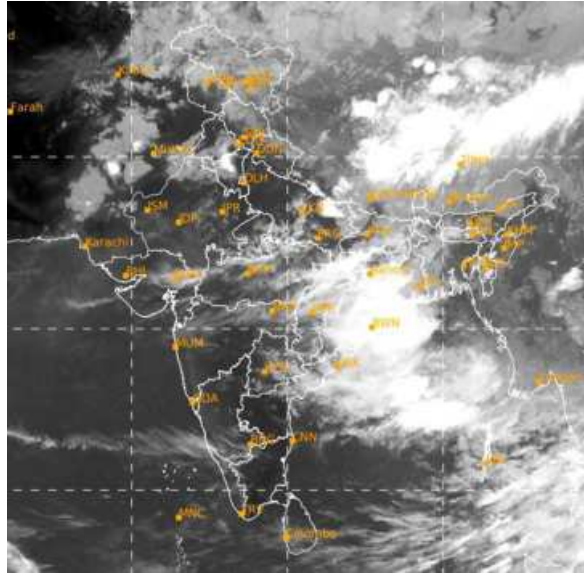
He had contended that if he did not retake the oath by July 14, the majority held by the BJP in the Corporation would be lost.

The court stated that it had a duty to uphold democracy when ‘the very pulse of democracy is made to collapse over a solitary, disputed oath’.

“The people’s mandate cannot be massacred by a procedural lapse,” the court held.

WEATHERWATCH

Rainfall, temperature & air quality in select metros yesterday



Forecast for Tuesday: Heavy/very heavy rainfall likely at isolated places over Bihar, Arunachal Pradesh, Assam, Meghalaya, Nagaland, Manipur, Mizoram, Tripura, Sikkim, West Bengal, Odisha, Jharkhand and Chhattisgarh. Hot and humid weather likely at isolated places over Odisha, Rayalaseema, Tamil Nadu, Puducherry and Karaikal

CITY	RAIN	MAX	MIN	CITY	RAIN	MAX	MIN
Agartala	32.....	30.2.....	25.2	Kurnool		39.2.....	26.6
Ahmedabad		38.4.....	27.8	Lucknow		36.9.....	28.2
Aizawl		32.0.....	24.2	Madurai		41.0.....	27.1
Bengaluru		32.4.....	21.0	Mangaluru	1.6.....	30.3.....	25.4
Bhopal		32.8.....	25.2	Mumbai		32.8.....	20.4
Bhubaneswar		36.2.....	28.4	Mysuru		38.0.....	29.1
Chandigarh	0.8.....	36.1.....	25.0	New Delhi		38.0.....	29.1
Chennai		39.9.....	29.6	Patna	6.9.....	34.9.....	26.7
Coimbatore		33.2.....	22.8	Port Blair		5.1.....	30.4.....
Dehradun		34.8.....	24.8	Prayagraj		36.4.....	26.5
Gangtok	53.....	32.4.....	19.3	Puducherry		39.3.....	29.0
Goa		33.5.....	27.4	Pune		31.4.....	23.2
Guwahati	30.4.....	32.2.....	26.4	Raipur		35.2.....	26.6
Hubballi		30.0.....	21.0	Ranchi		31.6.....	24.0
Hyderabad		36.7.....	25.4	Shillong		26.2.....	18.1
Imphal	0.6.....	30.1.....	23.2	Shimla		4.2.....	27.6.....
Jaipur		35.2.....	28.4	Srinagar		0.8.....	28.6.....
Kochi		30.6.....	26.4	Thiruvananthapuram		1.....	32.8.....
Kohima		24.0.....	19.0	Tiruchirappalli		39.3.....	27.6
Kolkata		32.7.....	28.4	Vijayawada		38.4.....	28.4
Kozhikode	1.9.....	34.0.....	26.2	Visakhapatnam		33.6.....	28.8

(Rainfall data in mm; temperature in Celsius)

Pollutants in the air you are breathing

CITIES	SO ₂	NO ₂	CO	PM _{2.5}	PM ₁₀	CODE	Yesterday
Ahmedabad		24	34	46		63	
Bengaluru		14	34	55		110	
Chennai		5	5	26		260	
Delhi		26	42	64		193	
Hyderabad		14	12	17		52	
Kolkata		6	32	29		90	
Lucknow		14	10	43		134	
Mumbai		7	97	10		25	
Pune		28	42	45		82	
Visakhapatnam		39	68	20		68	

Air Quality Code: ■ Poor ■ Moderate ■ Good (Readings indicate average AQI)

SO₂: Sulphur Dioxide. Short-term exposure can harm the respiratory system, making breathing difficult. It can affect visibility by reacting with other air particles to form haze and stain culturally important objects such as statues and monuments.

NO₂: Nitrogen Dioxide. Aggravates respiratory illness, causes haze to form by reacting with other air particles, causes acid rain, pollutes coastal waters.

CO: Carbon monoxide. High concentration in air reduces oxygen supply to critical organs like the heart and brain. At very high levels, it can cause dizziness, confusion, unconsciousness and even death.

PM_{2.5} & PM₁₀: Particulate matter pollution can cause irritation of the eyes, nose and throat, coughing, chest tightness and shortness of breath, reduced lung function, irregular heartbeat, asthma attacks, heart attacks and premature death in people with heart or lung disease

INBRIEF



Centre offers help to protect rights of retrenched tech staff

The Union Ministry of Labour has offered “all possible help” to address the issues of more than 800 employees retrenched by U.S. technology firm CorroHealth Infotech Private Limited from its Kochi and Kozhikode centres recently. Union Labour Minister Mansukh Mandaviya assured Kerala Labour Minister Bindu Krishna that the Centre would stand for the “job and social security” of all workers. Ms. Krishna told *The Hindu* after the meeting that she had submitted a memorandum to the Minister on the issue.

Man accused of killing six found dead in Telangana

A POCSO case accused, who allegedly murdered six people in Telangana’s Shabad mandal on Friday, died by suicide after consuming a suspected herbicide, he police said on Monday. The police said they had recovered his mobile phone. “In a video he made at 4.55 p.m. on the day of the murders, he says that he had decided to kill the minor girl [who filed a case against him under the POCSO Act], her mother and grandmother before killing his own family and taking his own life,” the police said. (To overcome suicidal thoughts, seek help at 14416)

YouTuber’s channel shut down over malicious content

The YouTube channel of social media personality Mohammad Nihad, popularly known as ‘Thoppi’, has reportedly been shut down after a Kerala Police report flagged malicious and obscene content. The Ernakulam Rural cyber police had booked Mr. Nihad for allegedly posting obscene visuals through streaming platforms, and registered a case against him on the night of June 20. He allegedly posted nude images of his friends on social media following a fallout with them. The police have since opposed his anticipatory bail plea before the court.

Ex-Minister’s son surrenders in A.P.

The Hindu Bureau
SRIKAKULAM

Senior YSRCP leader Seediri Appalaraju’s son Arav surrendered at a police station in Andhra Pradesh on Monday over his involvement in a road accident, which claimed the life of a shepherd on July 10.

The accused surrendered after the police produced prima facie evidence of the accident on the old National Highway road of Kasibugga in Srikakulam district.

Mr. Appalaraju was a former State Minister.

A tense situation prevailed at the Kasibugga police station as YSRCP leaders and activists gathered

there and claimed that Arav was not involved in the accident.

On July 10, the 45-year-old shepherd died on the spot after he was hit by a two-wheeler. The police then arrested Tyadi Siddardha, Arav’s friend, as the two-wheeler was registered in his name. The locals later claimed that Mr. Arav was riding the two-wheeler. The police verified the CCTV footage and found that Mr. Arav was on the highway that night. However, there is no clear evidence or CCTV footage from the accident spot.

YSRCP leaders alleged that the ruling TDP was trying to defame Mr. Appalaraju and family members.

Peace pocket



Catching the first rays: Visitors watch sunrise at the Kootagallu Thimmappana Betta, a series of hillocks, around 60 km from Bengaluru city, on Monday. Situated along the Magadi-Ramanagara Road, it is a favourite haunt of local bikers and travellers. K. MURALI KUMAR

‘Rainfall has major impact on elephant movement in southern Western Ghats’

Hemanth C.S.
BENGALURU



Favourite hub: Elephants near Kuttampuzha on the fringes of a forest in Idukki district of Kerala. FILE PHOTO

residents were interviewed across villages surrounding the Bandipur and Nagarahole National Parks and the Palakkad and Mannarkad forest divisions.

The CWS said rainfall emerged as the single strongest environmental factor linked to reported

elephant occurrence, and that the relationships were often complex rather than following simple straight lines. “Human land use mattered too, but in revealing ways. In Karnataka, areas of human settlement were positively associated with reported elephant

presence, suggesting that elephants there continue to use landscapes close to people. The authors interpret this cautiously: elephants appear to tolerate a certain amount of human pressure, but likely only up to a threshold beyond which they retreat,” the CWS said.

The study also found that land-cover mapping showed an increase in human settlements and a decline in dense vegetation between 2012 and 2022.

What stood out was how deeply local communities understand elephant movement. “By bringing these two aspects together, we were able to build a much richer picture of where and why elephants move through these landscapes,” said the CWS.

TTD member objects to Shivakumar’s offer

The Hindu Bureau
TIRUPATI

An offer by Karnataka Chief Minister D.K. Shivakumar to provide ‘Tirumala Nitya Harathi Darshan’ to MLAs, public representatives, bureaucrats and judges from his State has raised eyebrows at the Tirumala Tirupati Devasthanams (TTD), the custodian of the world’s largest Hindu temple.

The Harathi is offered to the presiding deity (Moolavirat) of Lord Venkateswara in the sanctum sanctorum in the presence of a very few Peethadhipathis, monks and special representatives, including the Special Officer representing the Maharaja of Mysore.

Mr. Shivakumar had an-

Karnataka CM has offered to provide ‘Tirumala Nitya Harathi Darshan’ to MLAs, judges

nounced that the government would extend the same privilege to the stakeholders in the government as per their protocol, and on a priority basis.

It is, however, not clear if the Karnataka government had held parleys with its counterparts in Andhra Pradesh.

Responding to the statement, TTD Trust Board member G. Bhanuprakash Reddy condemned Mr. Shivakumar’s unilateral offer, made without consulting the TTD management, as an “authoritative overreach”.



Unsafe practices

Safety protocols should not be given short shrift in tourism and adventure

Survivor accounts of the Vietnam boat tragedy last week point to two clearly identifiable contributors. As the weather turned rough and the speedboat took a sharp turn, it tilted to the left. The passengers – all Indian tourists – sitting on the right fell to the left side. Almost all the passenger weight shifted at once, the boat lost balance and turned turtle. As it capsized, the boat captain and guide escaped through the open front door. Others who found an opening also jumped out. Those who could not leave were trapped inside the capsized boat and took in water. Rescuers pulled them ashore where first aid and resuscitation were attempted before they were moved to hospital. All this took precious time and casualties mounted as a result. Some 15 Indians are reported to have died while 17 survived. Four Vietnamese crew also survived. The Indians on the speedboat at Phú Quốc were among more than 100 employees that a mobile company had taken to Vietnam on a corporate incentive tour.

Industry data indicate that some three crore Indians visit foreign countries every year, with a significant proportion of them coming from non-metro cities. Many of the survivors at Phú Quốc were from such cities. South-East Asia has emerged as the preferred destination, with Thailand and Vietnam joining the traditional attractions of Singapore and Malaysia. Many of these new tourist spots are developing rapidly but, like India, have not fully strengthened safety-of-life practices. For instance, just as in India, pleasure boats operators may carry enough life jackets or distribute them but often do not insist that every passenger wears one. Life jackets keep people afloat with their heads above water if they end up in the sea. In Phú Quốc, passengers were reportedly given life jackets, but it is not yet confirmed whether they were all made to wear them before departure. Another basic safety feature should be ensuring that passengers remain securely strapped to their seats so that they do not shift during rough weather or sharp manoeuvres. Even small shifts in passenger weight can significantly affect the stability of a speedboat. This norm was violated in Phú Quốc. Vietnam in particular has witnessed a surge in tourism, with Indians forming a substantial share of visitors. Speedboat rides between the islets of the Phú Quốc archipelago and the main island are especially popular among Indian tourists. The Vietnamese government has promised to review safety standards on such boats and upgrade them where necessary. But Indians, aided by governments and operators, must strengthen their awareness of safety practices, especially those related to fire and water safety.

True to form

The best teams are in the last four, but FIFA performed poorly

When the 2026 World Cup kicked off on June 11 in Mexico City, the air was filled with cautious optimism. This being the first 48-team World Cup, there were apprehensions that the group stage would be low on quality and feature many one-sided games. But hope stemmed from sport's innate ability to adjust, evolve and thrive in newer settings. After more than a month's action, it can be safely said that the World Cup in North America has been a footballing success. Though semifinalists France, Spain, Argentina and England are all former winners, currently ranked at the top and from the pedigree and established stables, there has been ample space for others to carve their own identities. Cape Verde – a tiny archipelago off Africa's west coast – qualifying for the knock-outs and fighting defending champion Argentina toe-to-toe, spirited performances from the Democratic Republic of Congo and Senegal, Egypt's near-defeat of Argentina in the round of 16, and Norway overcoming five-time titlist Brazil and stretching England for nearly 120 minutes are all vivid examples of the wide geographical spread of sporting excellence. In fact, nine of the 10 African nations in the competition reached the knock-outs, and Asia too would have had more than just Japan and Australia if luck had favoured Iran, which crashed out despite three draws from three matches.

However, on the administrative front, the tournament has been found wanting. There were problems galore at the beginning, such as forcing Iran to camp in Mexico and travel long hours to Seattle and Los Angeles, and arbitrarily denying visas to officials and fans. But governing body FIFA has not turned over a new leaf. Among the controversies was the way the Video Assistant Referee (VAR) system was applied in Argentina's narrow 3-2 win over Egypt. The African nation saw a goal overturned for a foul committed in the lead up but did not see the same yardstick applied for one of Argentina's. Another issue that left supporters seething was the intervention of U.S. President Donald Trump in the deferral of forward Polarin Balogun's one-match suspension in time to play Belgium in the round of 16. There is no evidence to prove that Mr. Trump's phone call to FIFA head Gianni Infantino influenced the decision, but in a scenario where the custodian of the game has condoned every wrong from the chief organising country, suspicion is natural. Starting from Tuesday night, Kylian Mbappe's irresistible France, Lamine Yamal's organised Spain, Jude Bellingham's effervescent England and Lionel Messi's evergreen Argentina will be back mesmerising the world. But it will be in football's best interests if its guardians alter their moral compass and march in tow.

Holding the Court accountable amid democratic strain

In late June this year, 23 Opposition parties wrote to the Chief Justice of India (CJI) Surya Kant raising concerns about the state of the electoral process in India's democracy. The letter reiterated the broad concern that the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls is exclusionary, and that the framework is burdensome for ordinary citizens. The Opposition's letter is also a gesture of desperation and disappointment over the Supreme Court of India's refusal to interfere with the massive and continuous disenfranchisement.

The erosion of the right to vote
In *Why India Votes?* (2014), Mukulika Banerjee narrates various encounters with poor ordinary voters. Ms. Banerjee, in the book, referring to Mekhala Krishnamurthy's study, cites an incident: A woman named Rukmini Bai was unable to vote in the elections for lack of proper identification documents. When Rukmini was asked why it was important for her to vote, she said, "My work is to sweep up all the grain that falls from the sacks and the weighing scales on the floor. At the end of the day, I sell what I have collected and I am allowed to keep half the money. That is my income. So you see, I understand the value of each grain of wheat. On the floor they look insignificant, just one isolated grain of wheat, but each grain that is added to the heap determines what I earn. My vote is like those grains of wheat."

For any citizen of a democracy, exercising the right to adult franchise is vital. But for those who have been marginalised from mainstream society, voting becomes a powerful political act. It reaffirms the recognition that they and their votes matter, and that they count as much as those of the privileged. This is why the long queues at polling booths, without class, caste, or income disparities, turns out to be a beautiful image of a functioning democracy.

What the SIR exercise initiated by the Election Commission of India (ECI) has done is to poke at the heart of this electoral enfranchisement. The modalities in which the ECI has invoked this process are also significant. The ECI has been successful in creating an atmosphere of anxiety for citizens, in a matter closely tied to their political identity. The right to vote is a significant facet of political expression envisaged by the Constitution. This right is now, however,



Kaleeswaram Raj
Lawyer at the Supreme Court of India



Thulasi K. Raj
Lawyer at the Supreme Court of India

The higher judiciary's handling of the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls raises questions about judicial scrutiny and India's democratic future

submerged in an entire overarching framework consisting of documentation, inquiry into lineage, appeals and as scholar Rudraksh Lakra calls it – 'digital structural authoritarianism'.

Role of the Court

When the basic structure of a democracy is directly attacked by the executive, the kind of response by the Court – a counter-majoritarian institution – deserves serious study. When a politically aggressive state battles the powerless individual with the entire state machinery at its disposal, one looks at the Court, equipped with the constitutional tools to limit state power.

The Bihar SIR case was adjudicated by the Bench led by the CJI on May 27, 2026. However, this decision came long after the election was over. The Court also has a disappointing history of postponing the final decision in cases after the state action in question has been already operated or implemented.

Therefore, as in the cases challenging demonetisation (2016) and the abrogation of the special status of Jammu and Kashmir, by the time the legality of the SIR was decided, it had become a *fait accompli*. This is the primary failure of the Court – not determining the dispute when time is of the essence.

Second, the way in which the Court oversaw the process was problematic. Unlike the cases where executive action is under judicial scrutiny, in the Bihar SIR, the Court actively involved itself and facilitated the so-called revision that led to deletion of several lakhs of voters. By virtue of several interim orders and a multitude of directions, the Court effectively administered the process. One finds a clear judicial abetment to the electoral process making it a collaborative exercise – quite unprecedented in the country's history. The Court's nature shifted from a forum of judicial review to an administrative body.

Third, the ex-post facto endorsement. In the Bihar SIR case, it was nevertheless crucial how the Court would substantively conceptualise the dispute. This was also determinative for other State elections, particularly in Assam and West Bengal. One could frame the narrative in either of two ways: first, as a technical question concerning the competence and powers of the ECI; and second, as a question of deprivation of rights.

In formulating the questions themselves, the

The right path for India's nuclear power development

International sanctions were imposed on India after its peaceful nuclear test of 1974. The India-United States civil nuclear deal, which was signed in 2008, ended the restrictions on the import of uranium and of nuclear power plants, with some critical exceptions. The free import of natural uranium has enabled India to grow its nuclear programme. Negotiations with major western nuclear power plant suppliers were started but had to be given up as their plants were far too expensive.

Homegrown nuclear advantage
Sanctions forced India to innovate. Every part going into India's nuclear plants was designed, developed, tested, and manufactured in India in patient partnerships between the Atomic Energy Commission (AEC) and Indian firms. The unit size of India's nuclear power plants went up from 200 MW to 500 MW. Now, 700 MW units have been developed. Four units are under construction and another 10 are being developed. India now makes the cheapest nuclear power plants in the world, costing approximately \$1,700 per Kw. The South Korean plants cost more, around \$2,200 per Kw, the French over \$5,500 per kw, and the U.S. \$15,000 per Kw. Therefore, India has the potential to become a major exporter of nuclear power plants.

With such a clear cost advantage and self-reliance, reports of plans to import nuclear power plants and technology indicate insufficient awareness of India's own capabilities and price competitiveness. The size of India's potential market for nuclear energy is so large that it would be rational for international suppliers to do whatever it takes to get a substantial share of this market. But would that be the optimum choice for India if costs are much higher or if it creates a new stream of technological vulnerability?

At this time, India has further strengthened its



Meera Shankar
Former Indian Ambassador to the United States



Ajay Shankar
Distinguished Fellow, TERI, and former Secretary, Department of Industrial Policy and Promotion (DIPP), Government of India

The country's nuclear future must balance growth with self-reliance and safety

leadership in technology as its 500 MW commercial fast breeder reactor is getting commissioned after overcoming many difficult challenges. Today, India makes Pressurised Heavy Water Reactors (PHWR), which use natural uranium as fuel. The Light Water Reactors (LWRs) use enriched uranium as fuel and are based on uranium enrichment technology which is more widely used in the world. India should try and develop its own LWRs, specially as the Nuclear Suppliers Group waiver permanently prohibits the transfer of enrichment and reprocessing technology to India. This should not be beyond India's capabilities, given sufficient resources and a dedicated programme.

Scaling up, staying self-reliant

The government has decided that by 2047, India will develop 100 GW of nuclear power capacity. To achieve this, the sector has been opened up to new entrants from both the public and private sectors through enabling legislation that is well-crafted and investor-friendly. The price of nuclear power in India is now competitive *vis-à-vis* thermal power. The use of the proven, cost-competitive domestic technology by new entrants would be the ideal cost-effective way to scale up. A large programme has scale effects resulting in lower production costs. Further, new entrants could potentially reduce project execution costs and time. Bringing in technology streams and equipment which will give India far more expensive electricity should not merit serious consideration.

To meet the enormous dedicated power demands of artificial intelligence data centres, small modular reactors (SMRs) are being considered as a solution in the West. However, the designs remain under development, with commercial deployment yet to begin. The AEC has offered its technology for 200 MW nuclear

Court leaned towards the former rather than the latter. Barring a singular question on proportionality and legitimacy, all other issues were misidentified. This is why there is no effective deliberation on the legality of the process, particularly with regard to its vagueness and lack of reasoning. The disproportionate administrative demand for (often impossible) paperwork, rigid time limits, and the discriminatory impact on minorities, women, and the migrant population were overlooked. In the adjudicatory exercise, there was no appreciation of the social realities of illiteracy, poverty and lack of institutional access for a substantial number of voters. Ultimately, the Court decided in favour of the ECI on all the issues.

Judicial accountability

Long ago, the liberal thinker Murray Rothbard, relying on the scholar Charles Black, noted that: "the state has largely transformed judicial review itself from a limiting device to yet another instrument for furnishing ideological legitimacy to the government's actions." In his classic work, *The Politics of the Judiciary* (1977), J.A.G. Griffith also exposes the judiciary's natural inclination towards the political branches of the state.

The Indian Supreme Court is one of the most powerful institutions in the world. Many decisions of the Court seemingly involving legal questions are essentially political questions. Therefore, it is necessary for the political Opposition to evaluate and criticise the fundamental aberrations in the judicial realm. This is part and parcel of the function of the Opposition, in today's critical times.

Manufacturing endorsements to support continuing executive excesses is symptomatic of any authoritarian regime. It is important to recognise that India is evolving into a system in which institutions have lost neutrality, as acknowledged by the Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha, Rahul Gandhi, in his speech at the recent INDIA bloc convention.

It is also becoming clearer that any radical change in the polity through the judicial process is unlikely. There is a recent global trend of expanding oppositional politics beyond conventional methods to people's movements. India's democracy must embrace such political praxis.

plants to new entrants. Smaller unit sizes to suit emerging market needs can also be developed domestically in partnership between the AEC and Indian firms. The market for SMRs in India would be a bilateral contractual matter between the generator and buyer. From a regulatory perspective, there would be merit in taking the view that a foreign-designed SMR plant should have operated satisfactorily for a few years before being deployed in India. There would be little justification for an untested SMR being developed elsewhere being first deployed, experimentally, in India.

Ambition needs caution

Given the critical importance of ensuring the safety of nuclear power plants, it would be prudent that new players establish themselves before scaling up. India's record on safety in its nuclear plants has been exemplary till now. This must be preserved going forward. This will be a major challenge amid rapid expansion and the entry of new players, given the prevailing industrial culture in India, where accidents at construction sites and operating industrial plants continue to occur.

A single nuclear mishap could trigger a strong public backlash, similar to the one experienced by the West after Chernobyl (1986), which led to nuclear power development coming to a virtual standstill in many western countries. It would, therefore, be prudent for new entrants to initially develop only a few plants and establish the rigorous internal safety culture required for nuclear facilities, subject to continuous external auditing. Scaling up can thereafter take place gradually, without needlessly risking safety. The goal of achieving 100 GW of capacity by 2047 could be achieved safely while also strengthening self-reliance within India and enabling the country to become a globally competitive player.

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Diplomacy over war

The fragility of the U.S.-Iran ceasefire is a dangerous setback that increases the risk of another devastating war in West Asia. Diplomacy must not be abandoned in favour of military confrontation. The United States should recommit to sustained diplomacy, respect international law, and pursue peaceful engagement rather than policies that fuel further escalation.

Jagjit Singh,
Los Altos, California, U.S.

S. Janaki

The passing of legendary playback singer S. Janaki marks the poignant end of a golden era in Indian cinema. Her extraordinary

vocal range and impeccable diction breathed life into thousands of songs across multiple languages. What set her apart was her unparalleled versatility — a rare ability to effortlessly convey the spectrum of human emotion. Whether it was the gentle innocence of a lullaby, the technical brilliance of a complex classical composition, or the depth of a romantic melody, she made every song uniquely her own. Her honey-sweet voice will continue to resonate in the minds of millions.

Namya Jain,
Hyderabad

S. Janaki's contribution to the meteoric rise of music legend Ilaiyaraaja and

several other composers was phenomenal. It is a testament to her extraordinary versatility that she held her own in Tamil cinema, which boasted stalwarts such as P. Susheela, Vani Jairam, and L.R. Eswari, among others.

C.V. Aravind,
Bengaluru

A celestial voice that expressed all kinds of human emotions and the poetic beauty of nature in its perfection has fallen silent. An endearing personality across generations and language regions, S. Janaki will be remembered for her soulful singing and humility.

J. Radhakrishna Kurup,
Ettumanoor, Kottayam, Kerala

The passing of the "Nightingale of South India" is a profound loss to the Indian film industry. Through her soulful romantic melodies and timeless folk songs, she etched her name into the pages of history. Her music captivated millions with its meaningful lyrics, emotional depth, and extraordinary grace. Her songs also served as a bridge that connected families, cultures, and generations. Undoubtedly, the enchanting voice and unforgettable songs of Janaki Amma will continue to resonate in hearts for generations to come, preserving her remarkable legacy forever.

Muhammed Muflih V.,
Puliyakkode, Malappuram, Kerala

At Wimbledon

Sports lovers across the world will certainly savour and cherish the epic Wimbledon 2026 final between defending champion Jannik Sinner and Alexander Zverev. Evoking nostalgic memories of the classic battles between the all-time greats of yesteryear, the summit clash enthralled and entertained in equal measure. With his awe-inspiring triumph, grit, determination, indomitable will to succeed, and never-say-die attitude, displayed under testing conditions and exemplified by his ability to bounce back after losing the opening set, Sinner has cemented his place as the

new star of the international tennis arena, signalling a generational shift in the sport. The memorable final will also be remembered for the grace and sportsmanship displayed by both players. Their sparkling performances elevated the standards of the game to sublime heights. That said, the legendary Novak Djokovic also deserves special mention for his lion-hearted performances throughout the tournament.

B. Suresh Kumar,
Coimbatore

Letters emailed to letters@thehindu.co.in must carry the postal address and the full name or the name with initials.

It's time to wean T.N. off populist doles

The Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam (TVK)-led regime in Tamil Nadu, which assumed office on May 10, has, so far, brought out two White Papers - one on public finances and the other on power utilities. While the first talked of “deterioration” of the situation in the last five years (2021-26) - when the Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (DMK) was in power, the second took a longer view of the health of power utilities over the last 25 years. The common thread of the two documents is: the precarious financial condition.

The profligacy of the successive governments has been a key factor that contributed to the very tight fiscal situation in the State. In the name of welfarism, they have been overindulgent in disbursing freebies. Afraid to wound popular political sentiments, the intelligentsia has also kept quiet. But such decisions should have been put to severe critical scrutiny as they reduced the availability of funds for public health, education, agriculture, and infrastructure - all of which come under development expenditure.

One classic example is the cash dole to ration card holders for the Pongal festival. What was started with ₹100 in 2009 rose to ₹2,500 in 2021 and ₹3,000 in 2026, the last two instances of which totalled to ₹12,300 crore. Despite distributing the largesse, the incumbent regimes were voted out in 2021 and 2026. Scrapping the scheme would not have made any difference to those who have been celebrating the festival with usual gaiety.

Unfortunately, the TVK too does not seem to have learnt any lesson from the experiences of its predecessors as its leader C. Joseph Vijay, immediately after being sworn in as Chief Minister, cleared a proposal for providing 100 more units of electricity free to those who consumed up to 500 units bimonthly. This was done as part of his fulfilling an electoral assurance regarding 200 units free every month to “eligible”



T. Ramakrishnan

Vijay and his Cabinet colleagues are in the best position to implement purposeful welfare schemes

domestic consumers. With this, the government added ₹1,730 crore to its tariff subsidy being provided to the State discom. The subsidy in 2025-26, under the DMK regime, was close to ₹17,000 crore. If the present government had, instead, begun cracking down on the parallel system of homeowners collecting from their tenants electricity charges that are far in excess of the official tariff slabs, the lower strata of society, which has been at the receiving end and which was said to have supported Mr. Vijay during the poll, would have got some relief on its power bill. Or, had it restored monthly billing for the domestic category, it would have made around 2.5 crore consumers happy. The government’s payment of tariff subsidy to the discom is in addition to 100% funding of revenue loss and equity share capital contribution. In total, the State provided nearly ₹33,400 crore last year just for maintaining “normalcy” in only one segment of the economy. In 2016-17, this was about ₹10,835 crore.

It is no wonder why the State government’s revenue deficit is always on the rise, especially after 2022-23, when the practice of 100% loss funding came into vogue. Power Minister R. Nirmalkumar, while presenting a few weeks ago the White Paper on the power utilities, stated that there would be no tariff revision this year. Maintaining the status quo appears to be the government’s approach in other revenue-earning areas. Another “welfare scheme” announced by this regime is the provision of one-gram gold ring to babies born in government hospitals. This would cost the exchequer about ₹756 crore annually and this will be implemented from September 15. As of now, the new government has not made any attempt to prune the welfare schemes.

Under such circumstances, it is unfathomable how the new government can continue with “key welfare schemes” of the previous governments as revenue

deficit is estimated to cross the ₹90,000-crore mark in 2026-27. Given the present climate of political instability internationally, Tamil Nadu, whose industrial and services sectors are deeply integrated with the global economy, is likely to experience greater volatility than many other States. After allowing 12% growth in the State’s Own Tax Revenue, the government’s White Paper on public finances has scaled down this year’s total revenue receipts (TRR) by ₹14,000 crore - to around ₹2,15,000 crore. As the committed expenditure - pension, salaries, and interest payments - accounts for around 65% of TRR, this coupled with freebies virtually erodes fiscal space for capital expenditure and investment.

Barring Mr. Vijay, who, at the NITI Aayog meeting three weeks ago, outlined his ambition of turning Tamil Nadu into a \$1.5-trillion economy by 2036, his government and Ministers have not spoken of grand plans for the State. Perhaps, this marks the realisation on the part of the ruling party about the government’s finances. Their enthusiasm in plugging leakages and tackling corruption is understandable, but one has to be realistic in accomplishing tangible results at a short time in a well-entrenched system. So, it is time the TVK regime made it clear to the public that it does not have money to implement universally applicable welfare schemes, old or new. In the process of ensuring targeted delivery of welfare measures, it may earn the wrath of certain sections of society. Still, this should not deter it from cleansing the system. As Mr. Vijay and most of his Cabinet colleagues do not carry any political baggage, they are well-placed to take radical measures to make the government’s finances healthy. Otherwise, the TVK’s promise of transforming Tamil Nadu into a “financially self-sufficient State” will remain just that - a promise.

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A cautious push for industrialisation

As land acquisition in Bengal remains tricky, CM says govt. will buy it for industry

STATE OF PLAY

Shiv Sahay Singh

The BJP government in West Bengal appears to be in a hurry to usher in administrative and legislative overhaul in the State and reverse the policies of the previous Trinamool Congress government.

Even as it has introduced new legislation to make preventive detentions easier, implement Uniform Civil Code, dismantle the statues and signage of the previous regime, and change names of streets, the Suwendu Adhikari government has also accelerated the push to bring industries to the State.

There have been several shifts at the policy level such as reintroduction of an incentive scheme for industry - which was stopped by the previous regime, exemption for investments over ₹100 crore from acquiring a no-objection certificate from local bodies, and re-examination of the West Bengal Urban Land (Ceiling and Regulation) Act, which limits private ownership of vacant land in urban agglomerations.

However, the biggest policy announcement for attracting industry was made by the Chief Minister on July 11, when he said that his government would purchase land directly from farmers for setting up industry. “We have accepted the direct land purchase policy of 2013.... With this policy, we are giving land to the BSF, railways and the national highways (authority), and for the new airport... Under the land purchase scheme, we will directly purchase land and hand it over to you,” Mr. Adhikari had said while laying the foundation stone for a manufactur-



ing unit at Dankuni last week.

While the shift in policy indicates that the State government is willing to go the extra mile to attract industries, land acquisition remains a tricky issue. West Bengal is the second most densely populated State in the country with over 1,000 people per square km and the average size of land holding being only 0.77 hectares.

About 20 years ago, the CPI (M)-led Left Front government had returned to power with a huge mandate, winning 235 of the 294 Assembly seats in the State (the BJP won 208 seats in 2026). Led by Buddhadeb Bhattacharjee, it was in haste to industrialise the State and announced the Tata Motors small car factory at Singur.

However, land acquisition for the project spiralled into a key issue, which consequently ended the 34-year-old Left Front government in the State and catapulted Trinamool chairperson Mamata Banerjee to power in 2011. Mr. Adhikari, who was part of the fight against land acquisition at Nandigram, is aware of the dangers of forcible land acquisition and how it could unite people against the government. “We do not want a repeat Singur and Nandigram anti-land acquisition agitations,” he said, emphasising that he did not want indus-

tries to directly purchase land from farmers.

However, the Chief Minister’s remark has left the industry without a clarity on land acquisition. Business houses say that a clear picture will emerge only when the government comes up with a land acquisition policy in the next few months.

During the 15 years of Trinamool Congress government, prominent industry leaders made proposals worth lakhs of crores at the Biswa Bangla Global Conventions. Often, they repeated the same proposals year after year, while millions of workers from the State moved to the South and the West of the country to work as migrant workers.

The decision of Tata Motors to leave the State at the height of Singur agitation in 2008 is considered a major setback for West Bengal’s dreams of industrial revival after years of militant trade unionism. Over the past two decades, the Left and Trinamool governments tried hard to shrug off the anti-industry image of the State. In those years, West Bengal lost the race of industrialisation to States in the West and the South of the country.

Starting late in the race, Bengal has to tide over several barriers such as land acquisition - on which there is no clarity, ensuring proper law and order that has hit its nadir because of misrule under the Trinamool regime, and improving its infrastructure that appears to be crumbling.

The BJP government’s promise of turning West Bengal into ‘Sonar Bangla (Golden Bengal)’ cannot be achieved without ushering in industrialisation, and that is perhaps the biggest challenge before the government.

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Is the undocumented migrant counted?

Evidence using official Census data suggest that there is no surge of undocumented migrants from Bangladesh, at least between 1991 and 2011

DATA POINT

Abhishek Shaw

Can India’s official statistics detect large-scale undocumented migration? Undocumented migrants may evade law, but can they evade the Census? If millions of them are living in India, they must appear somewhere in the country’s official statistics. Union Minister of Parliamentary Affairs Kiren Rijiju told Parliament that “As per available inputs, there are around 20 million illegal Bangladeshi migrants staying in India”. Then, they must come across enumerators during the Census. What might an undocumented migrant do in such an encounter?

They can respond in three ways: avoid or duck the Census altogether, contributing to coverage error; be counted but report India rather than Bangladesh as the place of birth, creating measurement error; or report the place of birth truthfully.

Each of these choices leaves a different mark in the data, which can be checked. Together, this provides a simple framework for asking whether India’s official data are consistent with the claimed scale of undocumented migration. But a framework based on birthplace has a built-in limit: the Census records where a person was born, not whether they entered legally. The same “born in Bangladesh” category contains citizens, visa-holders, and the undocumented alike, with nothing to tell them apart. What the data can speak to, then, is scale: whether a population of the claimed size exists at all.

Ducking

Ducking is hiding from the enumerator altogether. But hiding is not the only way to duck. A subtler version, for example, is to tell the enumerator “I don’t actually live here; I will be counted at my usual residence elsewhere” and then not to be counted at that other place

either. The outcome is the same, an omission, which is exactly what the Census is built to detect via the Post Enumeration Survey (PES). This has been conducted after every Census to estimate coverage error and reasons for measurement errors.

The 2011 PES finds a net omission of 23 persons per 1,000 nationally, or 2.3%, unchanged from 2001 (up from 1.8% in 1991). The Eastern zone, with States bordering Bangladesh and where “infiltration” claim is concentrated, is best covered (**Table 1**). What can be said confidently is that the population missed by enumeration is small, stable across the decades, and smallest at the border. This leaves little room for the unenumerated population of the scale the political claim requires.

Misreporting

The second option—being enumerated but recording one’s birthplace as India rather than abroad—is the one that costs the least and can be neither verified nor refuted at the point of enumeration. But it has an implication: a person who misreports is still a person the Census has counted. This is what would be termed measurement error. They remain in the total population, in the count by religion, and in the age and sex tables, but the birthplace entry is false.

If, for example, large numbers of undocumented Muslim migrants were doing this, the effect would not be a hidden population but an inflated one—a Muslim population, and with a rate of population growth, larger than natural increase and differential fertility can account for—and concentrated in the border districts. That inflation has been examined in an earlier article in *The India Forum*, which found no such signature. If misreporting were hiding a large migrant inflow, it would surface as border-concentrated Muslim growth beyond what fertility explains. The counts showed growth that is moderate, fertility-consis-

tent, and geographically dispersed instead.

Truthful Responses

The third option is to report their place of birth truthfully with the belief that the Census enumeration is anonymous and does not put them at risk. Migrant stock is a widely used measure to keep track of levels of migration. A person enumerated in India, but born in another country is considered a migrant in this measure.

The composition of the migrant stock in India has seen substantial declines of those born in Bangladesh and Pakistan, with large increases in that of Nepal (**Chart 1**). However, despite decline in overall migrant stock, about half of India’s has consistently been Bangladesh-born persons.

In the last three Censuses, roughly 94% of all India’s Bangladesh-born residents lived in the five border States (West Bengal, Assam, Tripura, Meghalaya, and Mizoram); a share that barely moved even as the national Bangladesh-born population itself fell by nearly one-third from about 4.0 million to 2.7 million.

Table 2 shows data from districts in the Eastern States bordering Bangladesh. Both by share and by absolute numbers across these districts, migrants who are overwhelmingly from Bangladesh are ageing and likely dying out. The younger age-groups show meagre numbers. Much of this population arrived during Partition in 1947 or the Bangladesh War in 1971. That generation is now elderly, and its numbers are falling chiefly because its members are dying.

Thus, the evidence using official data, in all its forms, suggest that there is no surge of undocumented migrants from Bangladesh, at least between 1991 and 2011.

The Census cannot tell us there are no undocumented migrants from Bangladesh. What it does tell, as checked in three different ways above, is that there are not 20 million of them.

Exaggerated claim

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Zone	Net Omission Rate (%)	Undercount in 2011 (millions)	Percentage of Undercount
Central	4.17	12.78	46.6%
Northern	3.8	6.07	22.1%
Southern	1.5	3.8	13.8%
Eastern	0.84	2.2	8%
Western	1.17	2.02	7.4%
Northeast	1.24	0.57	2.1%
India	2.3	27.67	100%

CHART 1: This shows the share of people, whose place of birth was not India, counted in the last three Census

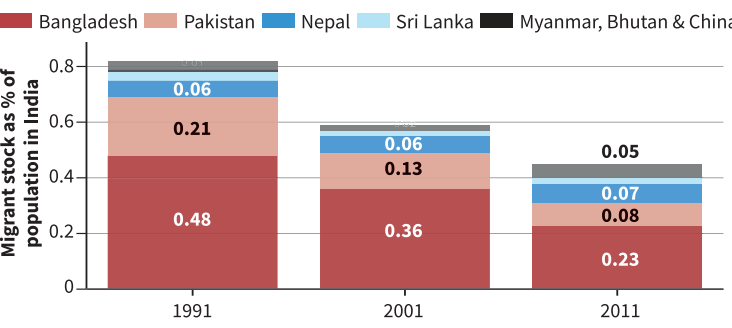


TABLE 2: This shows the number of people in different age groups and their share in total migrant stock in the districts in Eastern States bordering Bangladesh

Age group	2001		2011	
	No of people	% share in total migrant stock	No of people	% share in total migrant stock
0-4 years	2,699	0.2	1,982	0.18
5-9 years	7,348	0.55	3,467	0.31
10-14 years	22,991	1.71	7,030	0.63
15-24 years	72,081	5.35	38,340	3.41
25-34 years	1,42,446	10.58	81,108	7.21
35-59 years	6,48,416	48.14	5,01,655	44.62
60+	4,50,958	33.48	4,90,709	43.65
Total	13,46,939	100	11,24,291	100

FROM THE ARCHIVES

The Hindu

FIFTY YEARS AGO JULY 14, 1976

‘War Room’ for security steps at Montreal

Montreal, July 13: Major incidents are not expected at the Olympic Games. But should they occur, said the man in charge of the most elaborate security arrangement in Canadian history, “the tool is there.”

That tool consists of 16,000 armed security personnel, a force equal in strength to four army brigades. It also includes air, ground and marine forces, detailed planning, the expenditure of millions of dollars and complex James Bond-type scenarios to test the operations.

There is even a ‘war room,’ a sophisticated control centre, provided with instantaneous communications equipment and dozens of closed circuit television cameras sweeping over the Olympic village, the stadia, pools, playing fields that will be used by some 12,000 athletes from 120 nations, beginning on Sunday. The operation is presided over by Mr. Guy Toupin, the chief of the Canadian security forces.

A HUNDRED YEARS AGO JULY 14, 1926

The plight of returned immigrants

Calcutta, July 13: Mr. M. S. A. Waiz, Secretary of the Imperial Indian Citizenship Association, Bombay, is in Calcutta for a few days making investigation into the condition of returned Indian immigrants from the Colonies such as Fiji, Surinam and British Guiana. He said: “There are about 2,000 returned immigrants scattered all over Calcutta. Most of them are colonial-born and have come out to visit the motherland. Nothing will induce them to leave Calcutta, for one thing they have had a bitter experience of being ostracised by their own people and secondly, they hope that, one day, the Government of India will send them out and, if they are not in Calcutta, they will be left behind. they are living a very precarious life. If the Government of India, for some reason, are unable to help those unfortunate people, the different colonial Governments should be approached for securing free passages, for there they are all British subjects and their rights must be protected by the Government of the colony in which they were born and have spent the major portion of their lives.”

From Page One

‘Citizenship decisions must be fair, reasoned’

The remand was intended solely to ensure that the serious civil consequences of being declared a foreigner flow only from an adjudication that is legally sustainable and consistent with the principles of fairness, the top court said.

Accordingly, the Bench set aside both the High Court judgments and the corresponding opinions of the Foreigners Tribunals concerned, directing the tribunals to decide the matters afresh without being influenced by their earlier findings or those of the High Court. It said the fresh adjudication must involve an independent assessment of the evidence and the rival claims in accordance with law and should, as far as possible, be completed within six months. The court further directed that no coercive steps be taken against the appellants until the Foreigners Tribunals render fresh opinions. Justice Nath also acknowledged that questions of citizenship and foreigner status occupy a field of “high constitutional and legal significance”, particularly because a declaration that a person is a foreigner carries far more than ordinary civil consequences.

Retail inflation climbs past RBI target to 4.4%

“On the domestic front, food inflation has remained a key driver, due to weather-related disruptions to agricultural output, and uneven monsoon distribution across certain regions,” Vivek Rath, national director of research at Knight Frank India said.

Looking ahead, Aditi Nayar, chief economist at ICRA, said retail food prices have continued to harden in July too when compared to June as well as July 2025, suggesting that the inflation in this segment is likely to be even higher in July 2026. “In addition to food items, the non-food component may also exert pressure on the headline CPI print in the month, partly owing to the pass-through of higher fuel prices into prices of other items,” she added.

The other area that witnessed high inflation was the “personal care, social protection and miscellaneous goods & services” category, which saw inflation of 16.7% in June 2026, although this was the lowest since January 2026, the earliest period for which the new series has data. Inflation in this segment was propelled by the rising prices of gold and silver in June, which was exacerbated by the higher import duties imposed on the two metals.

Ram Temple donation case: SC seeks report

The court confined itself to issuing a formal judicial notice only to the Trust. “There is no necessity to issue notice to the others,” the Chief Justice observed orally after Mr. Mehta said he was already present in the courtroom and representing the State and the Union of India.

The top court was hearing petitions seeking a CBI investigation and protection of electronic evidence in the Ram temple donations’ embezzlement case.

A petition filed by Rashtriya Janata Dal MP Sudhakar Singh to provide and publish complete financial details of the Shri Ram Janmabhoomi Teerth Kshetra Trust, including foreign contributions, had sought the court to direct the Trust to prepare and produce a complete statement of cash donations, bank transfers, digital payments, foreign contributions, gold, silver and other valuables, together with the particulars of their accounting, custody and utilisation since its inception. Another petition filed by Supreme Court advocate N.K. Goswami has sought the protection of electronic evidence like CCTV footage which could be “quietly lost”, erased, overwritten or corrupted in the coming days.

SC stays Madras HC’s ban on cow slaughter

The State government also pointed out that laws such as the Prevention of Cruelty to Animals Act, 1960; the Prevention of Cruelty to Animals (Slaughter House) Rules, 2001; the Tamil Nadu Urban Local Bodies Act, 1998; and the Tamil Nadu Urban Local Bodies Rules, 2023, do not impose a blanket prohibition on slaughter, but instead regulates the manner and conditions under which it may be carried out.

The impugned order directed the Chief Secretary and the Director-General of Police/Head of Police Force to ensure that no cow or calf was slaughtered anywhere in Tamil Nadu either on the eve of Bakrid on May 28, 2026, or on any subsequent day.

The petition, filed by the Secretary to the State government, arraigned as respondents K. Surya, aka K. Surya Prasanth, youth wing secretary of the Indu Makkal Katchi, who had moved the original writ petition before the High Court, along with the Director-General of Police and other State officials.

The State government pointed out that while the High Court had correctly observed that slaughter could take place only in designated slaughterhouses or places notified under the law, it had simultaneously directed a complete prohibition on the slaughter of cows and calves.

All Ladakh districts to get autonomous hill councils

Ladakh administration announces creation of 17 new tehsils; Chief Secretary Ashish Kundra says several rounds of talks were held with regional representatives over constitutional safeguards

Peerzada Ashiq
SRINAGAR

The Ladakh administration on Monday announced 17 new tehsils “to strengthen grassroots governance” in the Union Territory and said the Ladakh Autonomous Hill Development Council (LAHDC) Act will be extended to all seven districts of the region.

“The administration is working on an institutional framework suited to Ladakh’s unique requirements and is also taking steps to extend the benefits of the Ladakh Autonomous Hill Development Council (LAHDC) Act to all seven newly created districts through appropriate legal provisions,” said Ladakh Chief Secretary Ashish Kundra.

Earlier, Ladakh had only two districts of Leh and Kargil. However, five new districts of Sham, Nubra, Changthang, Zaskar and Drass were notified in April. With 17 additional tehsils, Ladakh has a total of 32 tehsils now. “These initiatives would bring government services closer to the people, reduce travel for citizens living in remote villages and strengthen infrastructure and



Governance boost: With the creation of new tehsils, the Union Territory has a total of 32 tehsils now. FILE PHOTO

development across regions, including Zaskar, Drass, Nubra, Changthang and Sham,” said Mr. Kundra.

He said the administration has issued posting orders for tehsildars in 17 newly created tehsils. “Four new divisions under the Public Health Engineering (PHE) and Flood Control Department, along with five new divisions under the Public Works Department (PWD) and PMGSY (Pradhan Mantri Gram Sadak Yojana), have been created to strengthen service delivery in remote areas,” he added.

He said significant progress has been made in government recruitment, decentralised governance, and ongoing discussions on constitutional safeguards for Ladakh.

On the issue of constitutional safeguards, Mr. Kundra said several rounds of discussions have been held with representatives of religious organisations and civil society bodies. “The minutes of the meetings held on May 22 and July 3 have been shared in the public domain to ensure transparency. There is broad consensus on protecting Ladakh’s land, culture and identity while promoting inclusive development,” said Mr. Kundra.

Glaring imbalance: KDA In July, the draft shared by a team from the Union Home Ministry in Leh suggested that the Centre was considering a customised *sui generis* model, most suitable for Ladakh, under the provisions of Article 371 for the Union Territory.

Kuki group calls for Centre’s intervention on blockade by Nagas

Vijaita Singh
NEW DELHI

As Naga groups continue to block the supply of essentials to Kuki-Zo areas in Manipur’s Kangpokpi, the Kuki-Zo Council (KZC), an apex body of the tribes, met Director of Intelligence Bureau (IB) Mahesh Dixit and senior officials of the Union Home Ministry on Monday seeking the Centre’s intervention to the crisis and expedition of political solution.

The KZC members said the restoration of the popular government in Manipur on February 4, a year after President’s Rule was imposed, has been of “no good” to them. They said at least 15 Kuki-Zo people were killed, and 14 villages of the community burnt down so far. Ginza Vualzong, KZC spokesperson, said Chief Minister Y. Khemchand Singh has “nothing much to do” with the Kuki-Zo people, who are now looking for a separate administration - a Union Territory with a legislature.

In a meeting with civil



Leaders of KZC at a press conference in New Delhi on Monday. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

society members on Monday, Mr. Dixit sought the list of vulnerable Kuki-Zo villages that required urgent security, Henlianthang Thanglet, KZC chairperson said, adding that a memorandum has been submitted to Union Home Minister Amit Shah detailing their demands.

“In a meeting with Director, IB, we spoke about the atrocities and violence we are facing. How to solve the supply of food. He said he will look into it. We also spoke about the political settlement,” said Mr. Thanglet.

Border States flag illegal migrants on voters’ list, use of apps for smuggling

Vijaita Singh
NEW DELHI

At the first-ever conference of police chiefs from districts sharing borders with neighbouring countries, the States flagged several key concerns, including the presence of illegal migrants on electoral rolls despite the special revision of voter lists in Assam, the alleged misuse of the Nepal border by radical elements to reach Punjab, and the use of applications such as WhatsApp, Skred, and Zangi for arms and narcotics smuggling across the Pakistan border, a senior government official told *The Hindu*.

The migration of people from border villages is also an area of concern.

On July 9, Home Minister Amit Shah addressed the first-ever Land Border Districts’ Superintendents of Police Conference 2026. The meeting was attended by SPs of 119 border districts. Union Home Secretary Govind Mohan, Director of the Intelligence Bureau Mahesh Dixit, and Directors General of Police of 17 States and Union Ter-



Home Minister Amit Shah chairs the Border District Superintendents of Police Conference 2026, in New Delhi on July 9. PTI

ritories that share land borders with Pakistan, Nepal, Bangladesh, Bhutan, China, and Myanmar were present at the conference.

Key issues The Assam Police gave a presentation regarding a case where illegal migrants from Bangladesh were able to get identity documents and made their way to the electoral roll.

Unlike all other States, the special intensive revision of electoral rolls was not undertaken in Assam as the final National Register of Citizens which was prepared in 2019, is yet to be published. More than 19 lakh of the 3.29 crore appli-

Ex-AAP councillor, 4 others convicted in IB staff murder case

Ishita Mishra
NEW DELHI

A Delhi court on Monday convicted former Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) councillor Tahir Hussain and four others for the murder of Intelligence Bureau (IB) staffer Ankit Sharma during the 2020 northeast Delhi riots.

Additional Sessions Judge Praveen Singh of the Karkardooma courts delivered the verdict in an open court. The detailed order was awaited till the time of the filing of this report.

Hussain was convicted for murder, kidnapping with intent to confine, rioting with deadly weapons, unlawful assembly, and promoting enmity between different groups, among other serious charges. He was, however, acquitted on charges of hatching a criminal conspiracy and abetment of mutiny.

The court also convicted Javed, Anas, Nazim, and Kasim for the crime, while acquitting six other accused persons who had been facing trial in the case. Of the accused, only Hussain, Nazim and Kasim were in judicial custody. The remaining accused were granted bail during the course of the proceedings. The AAP leader’s plea



Former Aam Aadmi Party councillor Tahir Hussain. PTI

for bail was rejected by the Delhi High Court in September 2025.

The case stems from an FIR registered at the Dayalpur police station in Delhi, on a complaint filed by Ravinder Kumar, the father of the deceased. In his complaint, Mr. Kumar said that his son had returned home from work on February 25, 2020, but stepped out again. When he failed to return, the family launched a search, and was later informed that he had been killed. His body was subsequently recovered from a drain near a mosque in the Chand Bagh Pulia area. The post-mortem examination recorded 51 ante-mortem injuries caused by sharp-edged weapons and blunt force trauma. Mr. Kumar accused Mr. Hussain and others for the crime.

On March 24, 2023 the trial court framed charges against the accused.

Skred and Zangi by criminals and terror groups operating from across the border was also raised at the meeting. One of the officers said that the apps were difficult to break into,” said the official.

In all, there were five sessions at the conference covering transborder terrorism, insurgency and organised crime, challenges in border guarding, financial crimes and illegal flow of funds, changes in demography and habitation patterns in border belt, and community engagement for border development.

“The change of demography in West Bengal’s Murshidabad district was highlighted. So was the mushrooming of mosques along Pakistan border in Rajasthan. A police officer noted how the open Nepal border was being misused to enter Punjab,” said the official.

Another government official said that States have been asked to submit their suggestions by December and the quadrangular security grid will be finalised in the next year and a half.

Assam Rifles jawan killed, four injured in Nagaland IED blast

The Hindu Bureau
GUWAHATI

An Assam Rifles jawan was killed and four more from the paramilitary force were injured in a bomb blast in Chumoukedima district of Nagaland on Monday afternoon. The condition of one of the injured personnel was critical, officials said.

A Defence spokesperson in Nagaland’s capital, Kohima, said a suspected improvised explosive device caused the blast near Sukhovi. The victims were

reportedly returning in a convoy of vehicles to Dimapur, the State’s commercial hub, when the explosion occurred.

The Assam Rifles, in a post on X, paid tribute to the deceased jawan, Havildar Mohd. Iqbal.

Chomoukedima’s Deputy Commissioner of Police Nikho Venuh confirmed the incident. “A bomb disposal squad went to the site of the incident to ascertain the nature of the blast,” he said. The officials did not rule out the possi-

bility of a targeted attack on the paramilitary force. Last week, suspected extremists ambushed an Assam Rifles patrol in Ukhrul district of Manipur, killing two personnel.

“The bomb blast at Chomoukedima is a cowardly act that has no place in our society. Those responsible will be identified and brought to justice. We will not allow such acts to threaten the peace and security of our people,” said Nagaland Chief Minister Neiphiu Rio.

India, Japan review defence ties, prepare ground for 2+2 dialogue

Saurabh Trivedi
NEW DELHI

India and Japan on Monday reviewed the entire spectrum of their expanding defence cooperation and agreed to deepen collaboration in emerging domains such as defence industry, cybersecurity, space and advanced technologies during the eighth India-Japan Defence Policy Dialogue held in Tokyo.

The dialogue was led by Defence Secretary Rajesh Kumar Singh and Japan’s

Vice-Minister of Defence for International Affairs, Kano Koji.

According to Ministry of Defence, the two sides assessed the progress made since the previous round of talks and reaffirmed their commitment to further strengthening the India-Japan Special Strategic and Global Partnership.

The discussions covered the regional and global security environment. They also reviewed ongoing defence engagements, including military-to-military

exchanges, cooperation between the two countries’ joint headquarters, maritime cooperation, bilateral and multilateral exercises, capacity building, and defence equipment and technology collaboration, particularly in the maritime domain. They also discussed preparations and expected outcomes of the India-Japan ministerial engagements, including the next India-Japan 2+2 Foreign and Defence Ministers’ Dialogue scheduled later this year.

User data exposed due to flaws in UMANG portal: researchers

UAN of PF subscribers, LPG booking details, and Aadhaar numbers among the exposed data; IT Ministry acknowledges vulnerabilities, says necessary measures are being implemented; initial fixes do nothing to fix the system, says researcher

Aroon Deep
NEW DELHI

Multiple vulnerabilities in the UMANG, or Unified Mobile Application for New-age Governance, portal that aggregates hundreds of public services offered by the Union and State governments are leaving data of potentially millions of Indians exposed across a variety of databases, including those from the Employees' Provident Fund Organisation (EPFO), according to two security researchers who shared their findings with *The Hindu*.

The vulnerabilities, which have likely existed for years, affect several services tested on the UMANG portal, which has onboarded over 2,400 services. It stems from the architecture of the portal itself, said the researchers, Akshay C.S. and Viral Vaghela. "Almost everything is broken by design," Mr. Vaghela said.

The data exposed included Unique Account Numbers (UAN) with the EPFO, LPG cylinder booking details with at least one major oil marketing com-



pany, and Aadhaar numbers across several services where a user's ID details are saved. The Aadhaar numbers were found across many services in plain text, though such storage is disallowed by the Aadhaar Act, 2016. The Aadhaar module itself within UMANG was not vulnerable.

The EPFO module is UMANG's most-used service, recording over 40 crore transactions over the past three months.

The Ministry of Electronics and Information Technology acknowledged the vulnerabilities in a

statement to *The Hindu*. "Our development and security teams have carefully examined the observations and are implementing the necessary corrective and preventive measures," the Ministry said. "The plaintext information in the concerned APIs has been appropriately encrypted."

API review

The Ministry added that it has "reviewed the API transaction logs for the past three months" and found that "transaction volumes" were consistent and that it continued to keep a watch on activities on the

UMANG portal.

The Hindu is withholding the precise technical details of the vulnerabilities, as they remain active despite the above interventions. The encryption the IT Ministry referred to is "flawed and inadequate", Mr. Akshay said, adding that a simple workaround allowed it to be cracked anyway. At *The Hindu*'s request, the researchers shared their findings with Karan Saini, another independent security researcher, who termed the vulnerabilities "significant".

"Considering that rate limiting was implemented and the large number-space of EPFO UANs, it is unlikely that the vulnerability could have been exploited to mirror the entire EPFO database," Mr. Saini said, referring to the steps taken by the site to limit the number of requests a user can make. Still, he added, it "could potentially have been abused by cybercriminals in possession of UANs to siphon funds at scale by allowing for both changing of bank account details and initiating payouts, which is very concerning".

"The fixes initially im-

plemented following the disclosure appear to do nothing to secure the system and instead confuse obscurity with security, while also introducing another vulnerability in the process," Mr. Saini said.

Mr. Akshay and Mr. Vaghela reported both vulnerabilities to the IT Ministry and the Computer Emergency Response Team, India (CERT-In), which issues alerts and helps organisations across the country with fixes for vulnerabilities like these. Shortly after the pair reported the vulnerabilities, the EPFO took down its online portal for a "migration", and some services remained unavailable this week.

The researchers said they suspected this was in response to their alerts, which were also sent to the organisation. The Ministry of Labour and Employment did not respond to a request for comment.

"It is worth examining whether the fixes deployed on the UMANG portal were simultaneously deployed across the services for which UMANG acts as a proxy," Mr. Saini said.

Universities call for clear framework for disbursement of grants under VBSA Bill

Abhinav Lakshman
NEW DELHI

Appearing before the Joint Parliamentary Committee examining the Viksit Bharat Shiksha Adhishthan Bill, 2025, institutes and universities across the country have sought a clear framework from the Centre to continue the grant disbursement commitments currently under the University Grants Commission.

This came even as members of the JPC, including from the ruling BJP, flagged concerns that the Bill "does not expressly create a mechanism for institutional financial support". The panel is headed by BJP MP D. Purandeswari.

The VBSA Bill was introduced by the government to overhaul the higher education regulatory framework and intends to replace the UGC, the All India Council for Technical Education, and the National Council for Teacher Education with a single umbrella Commission, under which separate regulatory, accreditation, and standards councils will operate. The Bill notably divorces grant-disbursement powers currently held by the UGC from the regulator under



The Bill is currently being reviewed by a JPC headed by MP D. Purandeswari. FILE PHOTO

the new structure. BJP MPs, including Bansuri Swaraj and Bhartruhari Mahtab, and other members suggested setting up a separate funding agency or council under the VBSA structure in addition to the regulatory, accreditation, and standards councils.

Ms. Swaraj further submitted that the legislation should have a provision mandating that a "successor grant mechanism" should be established within a year of its implementation.

'Grant-giving powers'

Further, institutions like Jamia Milia Islamia, Indian Institute of Foreign Trade, Gauhati University, and Central University of Gujarat have said that removing grant-giving powers from

the regulator "may create uncertainty for public universities, especially State institutions dependent on Central support", calling for a specific framework to ensure these grants continue uninterrupted.

The Higher Education Department of the Congress-ruled Telangana government also added to this argument, noting that the UGC's general development grants – as they stand now – are the "primary statutory channel" of Central funding to State Universities.

Seeks assurances

Noting that the VBSA Bill calls for the repeal of the UGC Act without providing for a replacement for this, the Telangana government has sought assurances from the Union government to specify how these grants and funds to State Universities will be replicated under a new proposed structure.

The Union government has maintained its position during the JPC deliberations that divorcing grant-giving powers from the regulatory body was essential to avoid conflicts of interest and make funding to institutes more transparent and "performance-based".

Suspended staffer held in Badrinath Temple 'donation irregularities' case

Ishita Mishra
NEW DELHI

The Uttarakhand Police have arrested Pramod Nautiyal, a suspended employee of the Shri Badrinath-Kedarnath Temple Committee (BKTC), in connection with the alleged irregularities in the handling of donations at the Badrinath Temple.

Chamoli Senior Superintendent of Police Surjit Singh Panwar confirmed that Mr. Nautiyal was arrested from Dehradun on Sunday night and was subsequently taken to Badrinath for questioning.

A four-member inquiry committee constituted by



The accused, Pramod Nautiyal, being brought back to the Badrinath Police Station after medical examination, in Chamoli on Monday. ANI

the BKTC had found *prima facie* merit in allegations of irregularities in the management and counting of temple donations.

The controversy came

to light after allegations of irregularities in the counting of donations at the temple circulated on social media. Following this, a right-wing organisation,

Bhairav Sena, filed a complaint seeking an investigation, after which an FIR was registered on July 8.

In the FIR, Mr. Nautiyal was accused of misappropriation and theft of offerings made by devotees at the temple. He was serving as the personal assistant to the BKTC chairman.

Laptop recovered

The police have recovered a Shaligram stone and a laptop from the accused during the arrest, but no cash was found.

The State government had set up a separate three-member committee last week to investigate the issue.

Ram Temple Trust invites applications for post of CEO

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Shri Ram Janmabhoomi Teerth Kshetra Trust, which runs the Ram Temple in Ayodhya, has invited applications for the post of chief executive officer (CEO) to oversee the administration and management of the temple.

According to the eligibility criteria issued by the Trust on its social media handles and website, applicants must be graduates from a recognised university and should have at least 20 years of experience in administration or finance.

"The applicant must be an actively practising Hindu. Being a Ram devotee

Panel to complete the selection process within a month after July 18 application deadline

belonging to the Vaishnava tradition shall be considered desirable," the application notification reads.

Apart from professional qualifications, the Trust has also laid down personal attributes expected of the CEO. The successful candidate should possess integrity, honesty, and strong managerial and leadership skills.

The appointment will initially be for a period of three years, and the candi-

date will be required to reside in Ayodhya.

CEO's responsibilities

The CEO will be responsible for the day-to-day administration of the temple, implementation of the Trust's decisions, supervision of staff, coordination of religious and civic activities, and ensuring the smooth functioning of the temple complex.

A committee constituted by the Trust will scrutinise the applications and interview shortlisted candidates before making its recommendation. It is expected to complete the process within a month after the application deadline, that is July 18.

Court extends custody of 8 held in Ram Temple case

The Hindu Bureau
LUCKNOW

A special court in Ayodhya on Monday extended the judicial custody of eight accused arrested in the alleged Ram temple donation embezzlement case by 14 days.

The accused were produced before the court and sent to judicial custody till July 27.

On July 10, the prosecution had sought police remand of two accused – Ram Shankar Yadav alias Timnu Yadav and Subhash Srivastav. The court will decide on the matter on Tuesday.

Modi's anti-corruption claims exposed by Ram Temple row: Congress

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Congress on Monday cited the recent controversy over the alleged misappropriation of donations at the Ram Temple in Ayodhya to attack Prime Minister Narendra Modi's anti-corruption credentials, alleging that his "na khaunga, na khane doonga" (won't take and won't let others take bribes) promise had degenerated into "khaunga, khane doonga aur khilaunga" (will take and will let others take bribes).

In a post on X, Congress general secretary (communications) Jairam Ramesh said Mr. Modi's promise, made after he assumed office in May 2014, had turned out to be a "hoax", and accused his government of delivering "minimum governance, maximum cover-ups".

He said that the [Ram Temple] episode had exposed the hollowness of the Prime Minister's anti-corruption claims and described it as a case of "*Chanda Chori, Aastha Dhoka*" (theft of donations, betrayal of faith).



Jairam Ramesh

He said the first time Mr. Modi's anti-corruption plank proved to be a hoax was when former Prime Minister Manmohan Singh had described the 2016 demonetisation exercise as "organised loot and legalised plunder".

Meanwhile, Leader of the Opposition Rahul Gandhi, announcing his second interaction with students in Dehradun on July 17 under the *Chhattroki-goonj* (Students' Echo) initiative, also targeted the education sector. "And the truth is - India's education system has now become a dishonest extortion mechanism," he said in a post on X.

Fasting student hospitalised, Wangchuk loses 8.25 kg as strike continues

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The hunger strike at Jantar Mantar demanding Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan's resignation entered its 16th day, with a student from the All India Students' Association (AIS-A) being hospitalised for hypovolemic shock, the Communist Party of India (Marxist-Leninist) Liberation-affiliated student body said in a statement.

Activist Sonam Wangchuk, who has been fasting on the dais, lost 8.25 kg, the Cockroach Janta Party said.

"Mr. Wangchuk has lost 8.25 kg, his blood sugar levels have repeatedly fallen below 70 mg/dL (normal fasting levels are around 100 mg/dL), and he is experiencing constant dizziness, severe muscle loss and visible weakness, with his rib cage now clearly visible," the CJP said.

"Despite his condition...the Union government has not sent a single representative to initiate a dialogue," it said.

**GOVERNMENT OF PUDUCHERRY
GOVERNMENT PHARMACY
DEPARTMENT OF HEALTH AND FAMILY WELFARE SERVICES**
No.0704/GP/B4/2025-26 dt, 10.07.2026
TENDER INVITATION NOTICE
Online Tenders are invited on GeM Portal on 10.07.2026 from the eligible and qualified Manufacturer/ Importer/ Authorized Agent for supply of various Machinery and Equipments including Extracorporeal Shock Wave Lithotripsy, Highend Colour Doppler, Extracorporeal Membrane Oxygenation (ECMO) System, Pulse Dye Laser, Bronchoscopy, Immunoassay Analyzer etc., up to **31.07.2026**. The details of the tenders, terms and conditions and tender document can be downloaded from the website **www.gem.gov.in** and also be viewed in **www.eprocure.gov.in/epublish/app** & **www.health.py.gov.in**.
CHIEF OF GOVERNMENT PHARMACY
No.124/DIP/AD(PRESS)/ADVT/2026-27

**OFFICE OF THE SECRETARY
A.P.SOCIAL WELFARE RESIDENTIAL
EDUCATIONAL INSTITUTIONS SOCIETY
TADEPALLI, GUNTUR-522501**
e-Procurement Tender Notice
NIT Nos.12 to 17/APSWARE-Tech/2026 Dated:14.07.2026
Online bids are invited through the Andhra Pradesh e-Procurement Portal from eligible agencies, firms and manufacturers for the following works / services for the Academic year 2026-27.
1. Selection of Agency for Providing Integrated Coaching for Intermediate Public Examination (IPE), IIT-JEE (Main & Advanced) and NEET-UG at the following Dr.B.R. Ambedkar Centres of Excellence, each with an **Estimated Contract Value (ECV) of Rs.3.90 Crores (Total 11.7 Cr)** (Individual Bids)
i) Meghadrigadda, Visakhapatnam
ii) Amaravati (Tadikonda), Guntur District,
iii) Kota, SPSR Nellore District.
2. Supply of Furniture/Amenities - **ECV: Rs.1.77 Crores**
3. Supply of ICT Equipment - **ECV: Rs.2.65 Crores**
4. Supply of Electrical Equipment - **ECV: Rs.22.60 Lakhs**.
The bid documents can be downloaded from the Andhra Pradesh e-Procurement Portal from **14.07.2026**. The detailed tender schedule, eligibility criteria, bid conditions and other particulars are available on the portal. **Contact: 0863-2347445**.
Note: Any corrigendum, addendum or amendments to the tender shall be published only through the Andhra Pradesh e-Procurement Portal.
DIPR 5248PP/CL, Dt: 13.07.2026 Sd/- SECRETARY, APSWREIS, Tadepalli

**ODISHA STATE SEEDS CORPORATION LIMITED
(A GOVERNMENT UNDERTAKING)
SANTARAPUR, BHUBANESWAR- 751002.
Tel-MD 0674- 2340573, E-Mail: mdosscltd456@gmail.com**
Short e-Tender Call Notice for Procurement of Strawberry Plantlets for the year-2026-27
NIT No. OSSC/Mktg (Hort)-20/2026
Interested bidders may visit the short e-tender portal i.e **www.tendersodisha.gov.in** for downloading the document for Procurement of Strawberry Plantlets for the year-2026-27.
Last date of receipt of tender in portal - **28.07.2026 up-to 05.00 PM**.
Sd/-
Managing Director, OSSC Ltd.
1001/97/2627
OIPR-1001/1045/1/26-27/0020

**ODISHA STATE SEEDS CORPORATION LIMITED
(A GOVERNMENT UNDERTAKING)
SANTARAPUR, BHUBANESWAR- 751002.
Tel-MD 0674- 2340573, E-Mail: mdosscltd456@gmail.com**
Short e-Tender Call Notice for Procurement of TC-Pomegranate Plantlets for the year-2026-27
NIT No. OSSC/Mktg (Hort)-17/2026
Interested bidders may visit the short e-tender portal i.e **www.tendersodisha.gov.in** for downloading the document for Procurement of TC-Pomegranate Plantlets for the year-2026-27.
Last date of receipt of tender in portal - **28.07.2026 up-to 05.00 PM**.
Sd/-
Managing Director, OSSC Ltd.
1001/100/2627
OIPR-1001/1045/1/26-27/0023

**ODISHA STATE SEEDS CORPORATION LIMITED
(A GOVERNMENT UNDERTAKING)
SANTARAPUR, BHUBANESWAR- 751002.
Tel-MD 0674- 2340573, E-Mail: mdosscltd456@gmail.com**
Short e-Tender Call Notice for Procurement of Pineapple Suckers for the year-2026-27
NIT No. OSSC/Mktg (Hort)-19/2026
Interested bidders may visit the short e-tender portal i.e **www.tendersodisha.gov.in** for downloading the document for Procurement of Pineapple Suckers for the year-2026-27.
Last date of receipt of tender in portal - **28.07.2026 up-to 05.00 PM**.
Sd/-
Managing Director, OSSC Ltd.
1001/98/2627
OIPR-1001/1045/1/26-27/0021

INBRIEF



Aditya Birla to acquire Sprng Energy in ₹17,200-crore deal

Aditya Birla Renewables Ltd. (ABRen), a subsidiary of Grasim Industries, said it had signed a definitive agreement to acquire 100% equity and securities of Solenergi Power Private Ltd., which owns the Sprng Energy group of companies, from Shell Overseas Investment B.V., a wholly owned subsidiary of Shell PLC, in a ₹17,200 crore (\$1.8 billion) deal. The transaction will add a contracted portfolio of 5 GWp capacity (3.3 GWp of operational capacity and 1.7 GWp of under construction capacity) along with connectivity and development pipeline, it said.

‘Currency swap schemes get positive response from NRIs’

The RBI’s recently announced foreign currency swap initiatives have received an encouraging response attracting strong interest from Non-Resident Indians (NRIs) and overseas investors, thereby strengthening foreign currency inflows and reinforcing India’s external sector, MDs and CEOs of public sector banks (PSBs) told Union Finance and Corporate Affairs Minister Nirmala Sitharaman on Monday in New Delhi. Reviewing the progress of the schemes Ms. Sitharaman expressed satisfaction with the encouraging response and urged banks to sustain the momentum through enhanced outreach and innovative financial products, according to a statement issued by the Ministry.

Woolmark Company to focus on sports and casual wear

The Woolmark Company is encouraging the use of wool in sportswear and casual wear production in India, said its India country manager Ajay Pradhan. There are 60 licensed users of Woolmark in India. About 6% of the 255 million kg of Merino wool produced in Australia is imported by India, while China imports close to 85%. In India, wool is predominantly used for production of suits, jackets, and sweaters. However, in recent years, its use in sportswear and casual wear is on the rise. It is used as blends with nylon or polyester too. From clusters such as Tiruppur and Ludhiana to start-ups in the athleisure segment, Woolmark Company is working with stakeholders and organising sessions to promote the use of wool, he said.

FIR against ex-Go First board for post insolvency ticket sale

Jagriti Chandra
NEW DELHI



In 2025, NCLAT upheld NCLT’s order for liquidating Go First.

The Ernakulam Police registered an FIR against the board of directors of the erstwhile Go First, the Directorate General of Civil Aviation (DGCA) and two online travel booking portals over charges they continued to sell the airline’s travel tickets for almost two weeks after it initiated voluntary insolvency process in 2023, ‘defrauding millions of passengers.’ The FIR, filed on July 9, under various sections of Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita, 2023 (BNS) names all 13 directors including chairman Nusli Neville Wadia, son Ness Nusli Wadia, CEO Kaushik Khona, unnamed DGCA official, portals EaseMyTrip and ClearTrip and Resolution Professional Shailendra Ajmera. This follows an order from Ernakulam’s Chief Judicial Magistrate Court to the police to register an FIR and investigate a complaint by Yeshwant Shenoy, an aggrieved passenger and advocate. Mr. Shenoy, who lost ₹64,000 after booking Kochi-Mumbai tickets on the day Go First filed insolvency plea, claimed the board entered ‘into a criminal conspiracy to cause wrongful loss to millions of pas-

Trade deficit jumps fourfold in June on surging imports

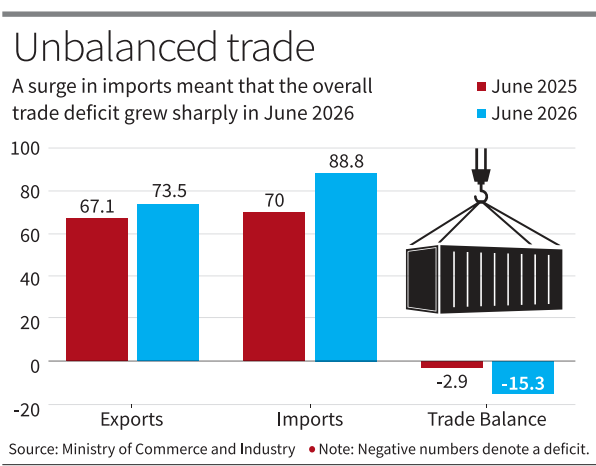
Commerce Ministry data showed India’s overall exports, including goods and services, grew 9.5% to \$73.4 billion in June 2026; total imports, on the other hand, grew nearly 27% to \$88.8 billion

T.C.A. Sharad Raghavan
NEW DELHI

India’s trade deficit grew over fourfold to \$15.3 billion in June 2026 primarily due to high growth in merchandise imports, which were skewed by a spurt in the value of imports of crude oil, electronic and electrical goods, and gold, according to official data.

Data released by the Ministry of Commerce and Industry on Monday showed India’s overall exports, including both goods and services, grew 9.5% to \$73.4 billion in June 2026. Total imports, on the other hand, grew nearly 27% to \$88.8 billion.

“Looking at the data, you would see that merchandise imports in particular have grown by a signif-



icant amount and think that this is a matter of concern, but the fact is that these imports are being driven by just a few commodities such as petroleum products and crude oil, gold, and electronics,” Commerce Secretary Rajesh Agrawal said during a

press briefing. “Gold and oil have increased in value because of higher prices due to the prevailing geopolitical situation, and electronics imports are rising because of higher consumption within the economy and also inputs being used for ma-

nufacturing,” he added. Merchandise imports grew 31% to \$70.8 billion as opposed to exports, which grew at a relatively slower 15.5% to \$40.4 billion in June 2026. As a result, the merchandise trade deficit stood at \$30.4 billion, about 59% higher than in June 2025. On the services front, India’s trade surplus shrank in June 2026 as imports outpaced exports. Services exports grew 2.9% in June 2026 to \$33 billion, while imports grew 12.7% to \$17.9 billion. As a result, the services trade surplus fell 6.8% in June 2026 to \$15.1 billion. “The widening of the June trade deficit is largely led by higher net imports of oil and electronics,” said Upasna Bhardwaj, Chief Economist, Kotak Mahindra Bank.

Emcure to buy remaining 12% stake in Gennova

The Hindu Bureau
HYDERABAD

Emcure Pharmaceuticals on Monday said it is acquiring the remaining 12.05% stake in subsidiary Gennova Biopharmaceuticals in a ₹232 crore deal. Gennova, in which Emcure currently holds 87.95%, will become a wholly owned subsidiary on completion of the transaction as part of which the 12.05% minority stake held by founder Sanjay Singh and others is being acquired. Emcure said the transaction is not expected to have a material impact on its consolidated financials or its capital allocation framework.

HCL Tech forays into full-stack AI market; to invest ₹3,500 cr.

The Hindu Bureau
BENGALURU

HCL Tech on Monday announced its foray into the full-stack AI market to utilise opportunities arising from the growing demand for AI-led services and solutions across private and government sectors. CEO & MD C. Vijayakumar said the AI data centre venture would be powered by a strategic investment of up to ₹3,500 crore, with the potential to scale to 50 MW of capacity. The proposed investment would be made through a new subsidiary of HCL Tech. “The AI data centre investment would be complemented by HCL Tech’s existing capabilities across



C. Vijayakumar

AI data centre design, DevOps and AI cloud operations as well as our software portfolio, enabling a truly integrated end-to-end play,” he said in a regulatory filing. The convergence of AI-led demand, supply constraints and push for digital sovereignty presented a compelling opportunity for the company to emerge as a full-stack AI technolo-

gy solutions provider, Mr. Vijayakumar said, addressing a press conference. Profit jumps 20% HCL Tech reported first quarter (FY27) net profit of ₹4,624 crore, a 20.3% year-on-year increase from ₹3,843 crore in the corresponding period a year ago. Revenue grew 13.9% to ₹34,579 crore as against ₹30,349 crore in the same quarter last year. The June ended quarter brought new deal bookings worth over \$2.4 billion, the company’s highest ever in a first quarter, usually considered as slow quarter. Advanced AI revenue accounted for \$171 million, marking 10.6% sequential and 62.1% yearly growth in constant currency.

‘Deal with U.S. ready but comparative advantage aspect still being worked out’

T.C.A. Sharad Raghavan
NEW DELHI



Rajesh Agrawal

The framework deal, or the interim agreement on trade, between India and the U.S. is “ready” and will be signed at the “right time”, Commerce Secretary Rajesh Agrawal said on Monday, however, adding that the key aspect of providing India a comparative advantage over its competitors was still being worked on. Regarding a timeline, he indicated that the deal could be signed even before the U.S. investigations on its trade partners are completed. “The framework deal is ready, and whenever it is the right time, it will be signed,” Mr. Agrawal said at a press briefing. “The Commerce Minister has also said in public that we are ready to sign, we are just waiting. Because deals are about comparative advantage.”

Preferential access “When you do a deal, you get preferential market access in India and India gets preferential market access in that market,” he elaborated. “These preferences are vis-a-vis some competitors. That is something that is getting structured. Whenever it is ready, the deal will get signed.” Mr. Goyal himself also took to social media to address concerns about the trade deal. “I had fantastic meetings with USTR Jamieson Greer, when he visited Delhi in June. Both sides reaffirmed their commitment to an agreement that is balanced, commercially meaningful, and delivers tangible benefits for businesses, farmers, workers, and consumers in both countries,” Mr. Goyal said. “Our teams remain fully engaged in achieving this

objective.” The U.S. is currently undertaking two separate investigations into its trade partners, including India, regarding their actions on forced labour and on whether these economies are using surplus capacity to export to the U.S. in a manner that hurts the American economy. The proceedings regarding forced labour are nearly complete, with the final hearing taking place last week and the final report expected some time this month. The draft report on excess capacity case is still awaited, with Mr. Agrawal saying the final process would take a minimum of 4-6 weeks after that. Depending on the findings of these investigations, the U.S. can levy tariffs on its trade partners. In its draft report on the forced labour case, it had proposed a 12.5% tariff on 54 countries, including India. Mr. Agrawal indicated that this timeline did not necessarily impact the deadline by which the trade deal would be signed between the two countries. “On the trade deal, whenever we sign it, all aspects of the trade relations will get addressed,” he said. “My understanding is that whenever we get into a formal trade deal, it will address pathways for some of these other conversations as well. A pathway can be done before or after the conclusion of those proceedings.”

राष्ट्रीय पृथ्वी विज्ञान अध्ययन केंद्र
NATIONAL CENTRE FOR EARTH SCIENCE STUDIES
पृथ्वी विज्ञान मंत्रालय, भारत सरकार
Ministry of Earth Sciences, Govt. of India
Akkulam, Thiruvananthapuram - 11

सं. एनसीईएसएफ/पी&ए/9477/04/2026
No: NCESS/P&GA/9477/04/2026 दिनांक/Date:13.07.2026

भर्ती/RECRUITMENT

NCESS invites online applications from eligible Indian citizens for appointment to the post of Junior Research Fellow (JRF) on contract basis for a period of one year.
Please visit website for details. Further changes, if any, will be notified through website only.

Website: www.ncess.gov.in / Phone No: 0471-2511500.
Sd/, प्रमुख, प्रशासन (प्रभारी) Head, Administration (i/c)

TRANSMISSION CORPORATION OF ANDHRA PRADESH LIMITED
(A Government of Andhra Pradesh Undertaking & An ISO 27001-2022 Certified Company)

e-Procurement Tender Notice

The APTRANSCO invites online bids for APT-e-02/2026 for Design, Supply, Installation, Testing, Commissioning and Comprehensive Operation & Maintenance of a Static Synchronous Compensator (STATCOM) for Dynamic Voltage Support at the Sri City Industrial Cluster, Satyavedu Mandal, Tatipatla District, Andhra Pradesh. The tender document can be downloaded from website <http://tender.approcurement.gov.in> from 15:00 hrs on Dt: 11.07.2026 Contact no's - 0886-2429230, Extn.: 2026, 2022.

RO No: GMCC/APTRANSCO/98/26-27 Sd/- Chief Engineer/Transmission.

TRANSMISSION CORPORATION OF ANDHRA PRADESH LIMITED
(A Government of Andhra Pradesh Undertaking & An ISO 27001-2022 Certified Company)

VIDYUTH SOUDHA, VIJAYAWADA-520004.

TENDER NOTICE

The APTRANSCO invites on-line bids for Spec No. PMM23-e-55/2026 for "Expression of interest for supply of 132/33KV 50MVA Power Transformers, free at destination stores including unloading, by way of trial order. Date and time of availability of tender 14.07.2026 by 17:00 Hrs. Further details can be seen in website(s): www.approcurement.gov.in For further details Contact No: 9491030732

RO. No: GMCC/APTRANSCO/96/26-27 Sd/- Chief Engineer/Transmission

JODHPUR VIDYUT VITARAN NIGAM LIMITED
Office of The Superintending Engineer (RE-DSM)
Corporate Identity Number (CIN) - U40109RJ200005016483
Regd. Office: New Power House, Jodhpur - 342 003
E-mail: rtsgdvnl@gmail.com, web site: energy.rajasthan.gov.in/dvnl

E-TENDER NOTICE

E-bids in two parts (Techno-commercial bid and Price bid) are invited from eligible bidders for the work for Design, Engineering, Supply, Installation, Testing & Commissioning of 1,00,000 Nos. of Consumers Through Net Metering And O&M For 5 Years With Additional 5 Years By Competitive Bidding For Grid Connected Rooftop Solar Plants Through Utility Led Aggregation (Capex) Mode In Jodhpur Discom Under Pm- Surya Ghar: Muft Bijli Yojana against Tender No TN-DSM-115 (UBN: JVV2627WLO800182)

Participating bidders can download complete set of bidding documents from e-procurement portal <http://www.eproc.rajasthan.gov.in> from 08.07.2026 onwards. Last Date/Time for receipt of online bids through e-procurement portal is 29.07.2026 up to 05.00 PM.

For further details regarding Works, Tender Notifications & Specifications please visit website <http://www.eproc.rajasthan.gov.in>, <http://www.sppp.rajasthan.gov.in> & www.energy.rajasthan.gov.in/jvnl.

Raj.Samwadd/26/6806 SUPERINTENDING ENGINEER (RE - DSM)
दिल्ली एनई डीएसएफ के लिए टेंडर प्री नंबर 1800 1800 6045

TIRUMALA TIRUPATI DEVASTHANAMS - TIRUPATI
HEALTH DEPARTMENT NOTICE INVITING e-TENDERS

Roc.No.TTD-33021 (47)/14/2025-HEALTH-TPT Dt:10-07-2026

The Health Department, Tirupati is inviting the e-Tenders (1st call) for "Sanitation Maintenance at Temples & Buildings under the control of Health Department, Tirupati for a Period of three (03) Years" in 02 Packages, vide Id's: 959964 & 959979. For information please contact Health Department, TTD, Tirupati, Ph: 0877-2264386 and for details login to <https://aaprocurement.gov.in>.

TTD-40021(31)/1/2026-PRO SEC(Adv.No.112) Date:13-07-2026 EXECUTIVE OFFICER

KARNATAKA STATE INDUSTRIAL AND INFRASTRUCTURE DEVELOPMENT CORPORATION LIMITED (KSIIDC)
(A Government of Karnataka Undertaking)

"Khanija Bhavan" 4th Floor, East Wing, No.49, Race Course Road, Bengaluru - 560 001, Ph: 080 - 22258131 - 33 / Ph: 9845520837
Fax No.080-22255740, Website: <https://ksiidc.karnataka.gov.in>
E-mail: bic3@ksiidc.com // harti.ksiidc@gmail.com

EXPRESSION OF INTEREST (EOI)

Karnataka State Industrial and Infrastructure Development Corporation (KSIIDC), Government of Karnataka, invites Expressions of Interest (EOI) from eligible private airline operators, airport operators, infrastructure developers, consortiums, and other qualified entities for the Management & Operation of Shivamogga Airport, located at Sogane Village, Shivamogga-577 222, on an "As Is Where Is" basis. Interested parties are invited to submit their proposals in the prescribed EOI format along with all supporting documents.

Important Information

The detailed EOI document may be downloaded from the KSIIDC website: <https://ksiidc.karnataka.gov.in>

- Interested parties may also obtain the EOI document either personally or through mail and seek clarification by contacting KSIIDC through the telephone numbers or email addresses provided below.
- The EOI document uploaded in KPP Portal on 14.07.2026 and Pre EOI meeting will be scheduled on 23.07.2026 at 11.30 a.m. and submission of queries on 23.07.2026 at 5.30 p.m.
- Completed EOI proposals, together with all supporting documents, shall be submitted in a sealed cover and delivered either to Deputy General Manager (IPD-1), The Office of KSIIDC, Khanija Bhavan, Bengaluru, on or before 17.08.2026, 5:00 PM.
- Late submissions or proposals received after the prescribed date and time shall not be considered.
- KSIIDC reserves the right to accept or reject any proposal, either in whole or in part, or to reject all proposals, modify or cancel the EOI process at any stage, without assigning any reason whatsoever. The decision of KSIIDC in this regard shall be final and binding.

For Further Information please contact: Deputy General Manager (IPD-1), KSIIDC, Phone: 080-22255740 Mobile: 98455 20837, Email: harti.ksiidc@gmail.com; bic3@ksiidc.com. And Civil Aviation Consultant Mobile: 94822 21795.

Sd/-Deputy General Manager (IPD-1), KSIIDC, Bengaluru.

SYDNEY

Sam Neill, versatile actor known for 'Jurassic Park', dies aged 78



Jurassic Park star Sam Neill died on Monday aged 78, his family said. The New Zealander underwent treatment for lymphoma and was declared cancer free earlier this year. In a career spanning roles across TV and film, he also starred in *Peaky Blinders* and *The Hunt for Red October*. His role in *The Piano* drew wide acclaim. AFP

MOSCOW

Russian and Ukrainian air strikes kill 10 people in both countries



Ukrainian drone strikes killed four people, mostly outside Moscow, on Monday while Russian strikes on Ukraine killed at least six — including on a cargo ship — officials said. Kyiv has upped its strikes on Russia causing nationwide fuel shortages. The strikes came as Ukraine's Volodymyr Zelenskyy met his allies in Paris for talks. AFP

WASHINGTON

U.S. sanctions Cuban militias, fuel importers and Tourism Ministry



The U.S. on Monday hit Cuba with sanctions targeting state-owned enterprises involved in fuel imports and other trade-related industries, militia groups and the island's Tourism Ministry. Since January, President Donald Trump's administration has pressurised Havana, with increased sanctions and an effective oil blockade. AFP

SANAA

Houthis fire missiles after 'Yemen govt.' says it attacked Sanaa airport



Yemen's Iran-backed Houthis fired missiles at Saudi-backed forces on Monday, hours after the rebels accused the kingdom of attacking Sanaa airport. The Saudi-backed Yemeni government claimed responsibility for the attack on the Houthi-held airport, saying it wanted to prevent an Iranian plane from landing. AFP

Trump restores Iran blockade, says U.S. will be 'paid' to guard Hormuz

Iran's military command says it would not allow the U.S. to 'interfere' in the key conduit for oil and gas, while also warning its Gulf neighbours against cooperating with Washington; U.S. hit targets in Iran while Tehran struck U.S. bases in the region

Agence France-Presse
WASHINGTON

President Donald Trump said on Monday the U.S. was reinstating its blockade of Iranian ports and "taking over" the Strait of Hormuz, where it would levy charges on shipping.

The President's declaration came after U.S. and Iranian attacks of a scale unseen since an April ceasefire, adding to doubts about efforts to bring a permanent end to the war that has curtailed shipping through the strait.

"The Hormuz Strait is OPEN, and will remain OPEN, with or without Iran. We are reinstating the THE IRANIAN BLOCKADE,



Boys play in the waters of the Strait of Hormuz, as smoke rises from an explosion in the background, off Bandar Abbas, Iran, on Monday. AP

so named because it is only stopping Iran's ships or customers from entering or leaving," Mr. Trump wrote on his Truth Social platform.

"The U.S.A. will be, from this point forward, known as "THE GUARDIAN

OF THE HORMUZ STRAIT," he added.

Hours later, the U.S. Central Command said it would resume the blockade on Tuesday.

Iran started blocking the strait after the U.S. and Israel launched attacks in

late February, which prompted Washington to stop shipping to and from Iranian ports. Those restrictions were eased after the two sides agreed on a memorandum of understanding in June aimed at ending the war.

Mr. Trump said that the U.S. "will be reimbursed, at the rate of 20% on all cargo shipped, for any and all costs necessary to do the job of providing safety and security to this very volatile section of the World." Iran's military command insisted on Monday it would not allow the U.S. to "interfere" in the key conduit for oil and gas, while also warning its Gulf neighbours against cooperating with Washington.

Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi mocked Mr. Trump over his vow to impose hefty charges, saying Iran would charge a lower rate. "POTUS is absolutely right. Whoever provides safe passage of vessels through the strait should be compensated. Iran has always been the GUARDIAN of the Strait and will remain so FOREVER. 20% is too much. We will be fair," Mr. Araghchi wrote in a social media post.

The U.S. military said it hit dozens of targets on Monday, while Iran's Revolutionary Guards announced new strikes in response on Bahrain, Jordan, Kuwait and Oman and insisted that the strait is "closed".

Group holds banner of Andrew, Epstein in Buckingham Palace

Sriram Lakshman
LONDON

A group of anti-monarchy activists unfurled a banner depicting the convicted paedophile Jeffrey Epstein and former Duke of York, Andrew Mountbatten Windsor, younger brother of Britain's monarch King Charles III, in the Throne Room of Buckingham Palace on Monday.

Photos released by the group, Republic, showed two individuals holding up a banner of Mountbatten-Windsor walking with Epstein and another banner in front of it with the words, "What did you know?" written across it.



Members of the group unfurl a banner. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

"We have taken questions about Andrew to the heart of the royal household," Republic CEO Graham Smith said in a statement.

The Palace was aware of the incident.

27 killed, 70 injured as fire rips through Bangkok bar

Agence France-Presse
BANGKOK

Investigators combed on Monday through the wreckage of a huge fire at a Bangkok bar that killed at least 27 people.

More than 70 people were injured following the blaze on Sunday evening on the outskirts of the Thai capital, officials said.

Flames ripped through the Rong Beer Na Lat Phrao bar and restaurant and burst out of the entrance, sending people fleeing, several with their clothing burned or ablaze.

"Everybody was running, squeezing into each other," recalled Athipat "Ice" Wijarn, whose bandmates were on stage when



Grim scene: Covered bodies of the victims laid out at the site of a deadly fire at a pub in Bangkok, Thailand, on Monday. AP

the fire broke out around 11 pm (1600 GMT) on Sunday.

"The fire spread very quickly, reaching up to the ceiling. Smoke was likely the main cause of death," Bangkok Governor Chadchart Sittipunt said.

"Most of the people who died were found in the toi-

lets. When the fire broke out, they panicked. There were no lights," National police chief Kitrat Panphet said.

Prime Minister Anutin Charnvirakul said initial inquiries suggested there were "blind spots" without a visible fire escape route.

For Iran, Hormuz is the key to deterrence and dominance in Persian Gulf

NEWS ANALYSIS

Stanly Johny

The memorandum of understanding (MoU), signed by the U.S. and Iran on June 17, promising to extend the ceasefire and launch talks on Iran's nuclear programme and Western sanctions, is falling apart. U.S. President Donald Trump has declared that the "ceasefire is over". Both sides have accused each other of violating the MoU.

The U.S. has carried out air strikes on hundreds of targets across Iran, while Tehran has retaliated by attacking U.S. bases in several Persian Gulf countries as well as Jordan. At the heart of the renewed violence lies a dispute over Article 5

of the MoU, which requires Iran to "make arrangements" for the "safe passage of commercial vessels" through the Strait of Hormuz. Iran has designated a new shipping route along its coast, while the U.S. Navy has cleared an alternative route along Oman's coast.

Last week, three tankers using the U.S.-backed route came under Iranian attacks. The U.S. launched air strikes in Iran, and the Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps has since announced the temporary closure of the strait.

In the MoU, the U.S. has made several concessions. It lifted its maritime blockade, issued a sanctions waiver for Iranian crude and other petroleum products and also promised that Iran would get access

to some of its frozen funds. After last week's escalation, the U.S. has revoked the waiver and reimposed some sanctions on Iran. But Tehran seems determined to retain its grip over the strait even at the risk of an all-out war and reversal of the purported gains of the MoU. Why?

A battlefield at sea

Both the U.S. and Iran see the Strait of Hormuz as critical to shaping the future balance of power in the Persian Gulf. While Gulf countries are exploring ways to reduce their dependence on the strait through alternative pipelines and trade corridors, such efforts are unlikely to significantly diminish its importance any time soon. In 2025, about 20 million barrels of oil a day passed



Ships and tankers in the Strait of Hormuz, Musandam, Oman. REUTERS

through the strait, along with more than 112 billion cubic metres of LNG. It also handled one-third of global seaborne urea trade, and 40% of global seaborne sulphur exports — together accounting for roughly 30% of global fertilizer trade. Whoever controls the strait

could emerge as a regional great power.

Iran believes that it has inflicted a strategic defeat on the U.S. and Israel as both sides failed to achieve their declared objectives. A closer analysis of the Iranian position suggests that Iran knew that its ability to shut down the strait played a critical part in this "victo-

ry", forcing the U.S. to agree to a ceasefire and later to an MoU which largely favoured Tehran. So Tehran doesn't want to give up this leverage. If the U.S. Navy institutionalises an alternative crossing along Oman's coast, Iran fears it would lose this leverage.

Iran wants to establish credible deterrence by asserting control over the strait rather than relying on American promises in the MoU, including sanctions relief. Tehran calculates that if it can absorb the short-term costs and institutionalise its control over the strait, it would fundamentally transform the country's regional position, and sanctions relief could follow. The U.S., for the same reason, wants to deny Iran that leverage.

Iran also has a long-term strategic reason to fight this war over the strait. When the U.S. and Israel launched the war on February 28, it was about Iran's nuclear programme, its offensive capabilities and its support for non-state actors. Both Israel and the U.S. sought regime change through air strikes to meet their objectives. Today, four and a half months since the war started, even the Americans are not talking about Iran's missiles or its ties with Hezbollah, Hamas, Houthis and Hashad. The U.S. wants to resolve the nuclear question, but Iran has tactfully shelved talks on the nuclear programme to the next round.

The first round - the MoU phase - was about ending the war and remov-

ing the bottlenecks in the Strait of Hormuz and the Gulf of Oman. Now that the MoU is falling apart and Iran and the U.S. are fighting over the status of the strait, the nuclear issue, America's principal strategic objective, has receded further into the background. In effect, Iran has tied its adversary to a problem that did not exist before the war (The strait was open and uncontested until February 28), while the original problem, the nuclear programme, has moved beyond the immediate focus of the conflict. For Mr. Trump, the dispute over the Strait of Hormuz should be resolved first - either through force or through talks - before negotiations on the nuclear programme can even begin.

‘From day one, I wanted to get my name on the honours board’



'I had a really strong feeling about Yastika, that's why we played her'



They have seen how special it is to play and win at Lord's: Gill



Tendulkar's words of wisdom to the team before momentous win



Team India completes a win for the ages at Lord's

It was almost a perfect match, says a delighted Muzumdar

‘Wasn’t the perfect ending but happy to play a Test at Lord’s’

A conversation with Smriti was the turning point, says Yastika

Facing India is always a challenge: Duckett

The England opener acknowledges that the visiting side will be tough to beat but is optimistic about the host clinching the ODI series

INDIA IN ENGLAND

Tarun Shastry

The hardest thing to do in modern-day cricket is to shift gears when you are already cruising. Fresh off a 4-0 dismantling of reigning World T20 champion India in the shortest format, England will face a different kind of test from Tuesday.

Awaiting the host in the ODI series is a significantly stronger Indian side, bolstered by the return of Rohit Sharma, Virat Kohli and Jasprit Bumrah. For England, the presence of India's talismanic trio demands a change in the gameplan.

In a virtual interaction on Monday, opener Ben Duckett acknowledged the scale of the "challenge" but insisted that England was confident of carrying its momentum into the 50-over assignment.

"Obviously, it's a different format, so there will be slight changes. Rohit, Virat and Jasprit are three of the greatest players to play this format. Any side with them is always extremely tough to beat," said Duckett.

"Shubman Gill is back as well, so there's a lot of class in that side. They're (Rohit, Kohli and Gill) players we've faced before, and I'm sure our bowlers will have plans for them. Jasprit is probably the best all-format bowler in the world, so any Indian side with him is



In awe: Duckett was all praise for skipper Brook's aggressive and fearless approach. GETTY IMAGES

always a huge challenge," added the 31-year-old.

The left-hander, however, remained optimistic about the home side clinching the series. "We're confident coming into this week. We've got a lot of guys playing well, too, so it should be a good series. We certainly fancy our chances," he said.

Duckett reserved special praise for England's white-ball captain Harry Brook, crediting him for fostering an "aggressive and fearless" approach within the

group. "Brookie leads by example. He wants us to play attacking cricket, and that's exactly how he plays. He's always looking to take wickets with attacking fields. As a batter, there aren't many better all-format players than him in the world right now. We're very fortunate to have him leading us."

(Watch the three-match ODI series between England and India Live on Sony Sports Ten 1 SD & HD & Sony Sports Ten 5 SD & HD from July 14).

ENGLAND
VS
INDIA

TODAY, 2:30 PM

SONY
SPORTS 1

SONY
SPORTS 4

SONY
SPORTS 5

தமிழ்

SNAPSHOTS

Wekunagoda on the double

GALLE: An unbeaten 203 from Senuja Wekunagoda helped Sri Lanka u-19 take control of the first Youth Test against India u-19, racing to 344 for four on the opening day here on Monday.

The scores: Sri Lanka u-19 344/4 in 89 overs (Senuja Wekunagoda batting 203, Vimath Dinsara 52) vs India u-19. **Toss:** Sri Lanka.

Divyanshi triumphs

HAMBURG: India's top seed Divyanshi Jain clinched the girls' under-13 title at the European Junior Open squash tournament here on Sunday, defeating Egypt's Talia Eslam 12-10, 11-9, 11-2 in the final. India also won two bronze with Aaron Arambhan reaching the boys' u-13 semifinals and Dhruv Johri making the last four in u-15.

Good day for Indians

JAKARTA: Indian boxers remained a strong force at the Asian under-19 and u-23 championships with eight of them advancing to the finals across men's and women's u-23 categories and seven others securing bronze medals on Sunday. **The results: U-23 (semifinals): Women: 54kg:** Nisha bt Hyeju Lee (Kor) RSC; **60kg:** Nikita Chand bt Sarri Kokufu (Jpn) RSC; **65kg:** Kajal bt Gulzina Melsvek (Kgz) RSC; **75kg:** Muskan bt Toirova Oysha (Uzb) 5-0; **+80kg:** Priyanka bt Panar Seitkhankyzy (Kaz) 5-0. **Men: 50kg:** Vishvanath Suresh bt Vicera Clark 5-0; **55kg:** Ganga bt Fuma Kumamoto (Jpn) 3-2; **65kg:** Vanshaj bt Omar Livaza (Kgz) 4-1.

Blue Avengers in final

CHENNAI: Blue Avengers beat Red Rangers by 42 runs in the TNCA Freyer Trophy women's T20 tournament semifinal on



Abhiman (5/17, Heartfulness IS NIOS-A); Rithaesh (Ramachandras PS, 104); Abinav (Heartfulness IS CBSE, 100 n.o.).

Monday.

The scores: Semifinals: Orange Dragons 113/7 in 20 overs (S.G. Shrinithi 36, V.R. Yeshwanthika 49, P. Sonika 3/17) lost to Silver Strikers 116/5 in 19.3 overs (Trisha Madhu 47 n.o.). Blue Avengers 143/4 in 20 overs (C. Shushanthika 58, Chinmayi 42 n.o.) bt Red Rangers 101/5 in 20 overs (Roshini Rajasekaran 46 n.o., S. Keerthi Sree 3/8).

Abhiman scalps five

M.P. Abhiman Sundar claimed five for 17 as Heartfulness IS NIOS-A crushed Sishya OMR by 201 runs to enter the quarterfinals of the Tagore Sports-TNCA city schools under-16 tournament, for the C. Ramaswamy Trophy, on Monday.

The scores (pre-quarterfinals): Heartfulness IS (CBSE) 186/5 in 30 overs (S.A. Aravind 36, V. Abinav Santhosh 100 n.o.) bt Jawahar Vidyalaya-A 93 in 24.4 overs (M.K. Nikhil 31, Tarun Raj 4/25). Olive Tree Global 137/7 in 30 overs (Juhaim Sulthan 46) lost to St. Bede's-A 138/1 in 21.4 overs (V. Samjeevaa 48 n.o., V. Sachin 67). Don Bosco-B 157/3 in 30 overs (Mayank Dhruva 80, G. Sarvesh 37) bt Ebenezer-A (Korattur) 150/7 in 30 overs (K.C. Krish 39). St. Bede's-B 122/9 in 30 overs (S. Prajan 36, V.S. Pranav 3/3) bt St. Michael's Academy 77 in 24.1 overs (S. Prajan 3/18). Vidya Mandir 118 in 29.1 overs (A. Siddarth 3/13) lost to Heartfulness IS NIOS-B 119/1 in 16.1 overs (R. Adhavan 51, R. Harshad 51 n.o.). Ramachandras PS 200/3 in 30 overs (V. Rithaesh 104, S.R. Sarvesh 36, Y.S. Arvind 35 n.o.) bt Santhome-A 120 in 27.2 overs (B. Srisai 52 n.o., Tharun 3/13). Heartfulness IS NIOS-A 272/2 in 30 overs (S. Ishan Praviit 64, Ruthvik Muralidharan 80, D. Prathish 80 n.o., G. Aadhiran 36

n.o.) bt Sishya OMR 71 in 17.3 overs (M.P. Abhiman Sundar 5/17, V.S. Pugal Maran 3/7). PSBB (N) 161/6 in 30 overs (Rishab Malhotra 43) bt The PSBB Millennium-A 42 in 19.5 overs (Vansh Kumar Jain 3/3, S. V. Rithik 3/9).

Sanya, lone Indian in the last four

Sanya Vats was the lone Indian to advance to the semifinals of the HCL squash PSA Challenger Tour-Chennai at the ISA. **The results (quarterfinals): Men:** Md Syafiq Kamal (Mas) bt Hugo Jaen (Esp) 11-8, 11-3, 11-7; Joachim Chuah (Mas) bt Om Semwal 11-3, 11-5, 11-9; Salah Eltorgman (Can) bt Wa Sern Low (Mas) 9-11, 10-12, 11-4, 11-1, 11-4; Adham Roshdy (Egy) bt Suraj Chand 8-11, 11-5, 12-10, 11-7. **Women:** Sanya Vats bt Unnati Tripathi 11-6, 11-5, 8-11, 11-8; Rougaia Othman (Egy) bt Pooja Arthi Raghu 11-9, 13-11, 11-7; Hwayeong Eum (Kor) bt Rathika Seelan 11-13, 11-4, 11-6, 11-5; Hana Aladdin (Egy) bt Thanusaa Uthrian (Mas) 7-11, 11-7, 11-2, 8-11, 13-11.

ENGAGEMENTS

Cricket: Tagore Sports-TNCA City Schools u-16 tournament (quarterfinals): St. Bede's-A vs. Ramachandras PS (GE-A); St. Bede's-B vs. Heartfulness IS (NIOS)-A, Fomra-B; Heartfulness IS (CBSE) vs. Heartfulness IS (NIOS)-B, GE-B; Don Bosco-B vs. PSBB (N), Fomra-A, 9 a.m.

LIVE TELECAST

England vs India: First ODI, Sony Sports Ten 1 & JioHotstar, 3.30 p.m.

FIFA World Cup: Unite8 Sports 1, 2 & Z5 App, 12.30 a.m. (Wednesday).



Sea Hawks takes lead with a record chase



Sachin (Sea Hawks, 245); Jagadeesan (Sea Hawks, 115); Lokeshwar (Sea Hawks, 129 n.o.); Raheja (Vijay, 145); Om Nitin (Vijay, 101).

FIRST DIVISION

Sports Bureau CHENNAI

Opener B. Sachin struck a career-best 245 (351b, 24x4, 9x6) while skipper N. Jagadeesan (115, 176b, 12x4, 2x6) and S. Lokeshwar (129 n.o., 206b, 11x4) hit tons as Sea Hawks completed a record chase for the first-innings lead, achieving the feat against Nelson SC on the final day of their TNCA first division game here on Monday.

Sea Hawks overhauled Nelson's 555 in 127.4 overs, eclipsing the previous record of 531 for eight, held by AG's Office in 2023.

The scores (sixth round, day three): At Tagore: Nelson 555 drew with Sea Hawks 557/2 in

127.4 overs (B. Sachin 245, N. Jagadeesan 115, S. Lokeshwar 129 n.o., R.S. Mokit Hariharan 50 n.o.). **Points: Sea Hawks 5(23), Nelson 1(18).** **At Vinayaka Mission:** Singam Pulis 175 & 266 in 111.3 overs (R. Ram Arvindh 60, U. Mukilesh 50, R. Sibbi 51, R. Bharat Srinivas 4/82) drew with Grand Slam 96 & 94/1 in 30 overs (Aditya Venkatesh 53 n.o.). **Singam Pulis 5(13), Grand Slam 1(19).** **At CSK-Guru Nanak:** Young Stars 445 drew with Vijay 439/8 in 114 overs (Tushar Raheja 145, K. Om Nitin 101, B. Aparajith 89). **Vijay 2(29), Young Stars 2(17).** **At RKM-Vivekananda:** Pristine 155 & 204/8 in 101 overs (Siddharth Mahadevan 74, M. Ganesh Moothi 4/54) drew with SKM 299. **SKM 5(14), Pristine 1(10).** **At MRF-Pachaiyappa's:** Globe Trotters 453/8 decl. bt Swaraj 164 in 75.2 overs (L. Ramnath 41) & 113 in 49.4 overs (V. Sathyanarayanan 54 n.o.). **Trotters 6(10), Swaraj 0(13).**

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TENDER NOTICE

Tender Notice No.: CWE/MTN/85265988/2026 Due on 10.08.2026

Tender No.: 85265988; Tender Title: Bogie Frame for LHB Coaches Coll Spring Type as per RCF Drg No. LW03007 Alt G OR Latest & MDTs 213 REV.04 OR Latest; Qty: 100 Nos.; Due Date: 10.08.2026; Value: Rs. 3,30,40,000/- Details to be seen on website www.ireps.gov.in DE/355

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Notice Ref No. JEPC/ICT/52/88/2025/2770, dated 10/07/2026.

e-Procurement Notice (Re-tender)

Jharkhand Education Project Council invites proposal for Selection of agency for establishment of Smart Class which includes Supply, Installation and 3 year maintenance of Hardware, Software & Connected accessories in the 288 Selected PM Shree Schools. The detail Bid document can be seen in the portal www.gem.gov.in with Bid Reference number -GEM/2026/B/7766925 only. Interested bidder can submit their bid through the portal www.gem.gov.in latest by 20.07.2026 till 5:00 PM

Sd/- (Shashi Ranjan) State Project Director

PR 384774 Jharkhand Education Project Council(26-27),D

CHITTARANJAN LOCOMOTIVE WORKS

NOTIFICATION FOR ENGAGEMENT OF ONE HOMEOPATHIC CONSULTANT AT CHITTARANJAN LOCOMOTIVE WORKS (CLW), CHITTARANJAN

Notification No. MW/Wel/SBF/Homeopath Consultant/Selection, Dated,08.07.2026. The CLW, Chittaranjan, proposes to engage one Homeopathic Consultant for one year, on contract basis at a monthly consolidated remuneration of Rupees 37,500/- P.M. Required Qualification: BHMS/DHMS. Age limit: 70 years (as on 31.08.2027). Last Date of application (to be received at AWO, CLW): 29.07.2026. Date of Viva-voce: 03.08.2026 (Tentative). Willing eligible candidates may like to apply against the notification may please visit the website www.clw.indianrailways.gov.in -> Login -> News & Recruitment -> Recruitment.

PR3/419 PCPO & Chairman SBEMC

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PUBLIC WORKS DEPARTMENT (www.kpwd.gov.in)

Office of the Executive Engineer, PWD Bangalore Division, 2nd Floor, PWD Annexure Building, K.R. Circle, Bangalore - 01 Telephone No. 080-22133370, Email ID: eepwdbngdn@yahoo.com E-portal : https://kppp.karnataka.gov.in/#/portal/portal-home

Short Term Tender Notification No. 17/2026-27 DATED: 13.07.2026

Item-rate tenders, for the work in PWD, Devanahalli Sub Division under this office noted below, are invited by the undersigned on behalf of the Governor of Karnataka in accordance with Karnataka Transparency in Public Procurement rules 2000 and as per Standard Tender Documents for procurement of works from the contractors registered in K.P.W.D. as per KPPP.

Tender Notification are Published for 01 Work Bridge (Rs. 550.00 Lakhs) Details of the tender works can be obtained from the above Office during office hours on working days. EMD & Tender processing fees are mentioned in KPP portal.

1. Tenders must be submitted online through KPP portal on or before 4.00 PM on Dated: 28.07.2026 2. The opening of tenders through KPP portal on Dated: 29.07.2026 at 4.30 PM or further date and time will be Intimate. For more details contact this office.

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अति अल्पकालीन ई-निविदा प्रसंग संख्या - RCD/DEOGHAR/1254/2026-27 (1st Call) दिनांक -11.07.2026

क्र.	कार्य का नाम	लालगढ़-बसकुपी पथ के किमी0 5th(P), 6th(P), 7th(P), 8th(P), 9th(P), 10th(P) के विभिन्न पथों में साधारण मरम्मत, किमी0 1st(P), 2nd(P), 3rd(P), 4th(P) में विशेष मरम्मत एवं अन्य कार्य।
2.	प्राक्कलित राशि (रुपये में)	रुपये 1,80,00,000 /- (एक करोड़ अस्सी लाख रुपये)
3.	कार्य समाप्ति की अवधि	02 (दो) माह।
4.	निविदा प्राप्ति की अंतिम तिथि एवं समय	03.08.2026 (12:00 बजे दिन तक)
5.	वेबसाइट पर निविदा प्रकाशित होने की तिथि एवं समय	21.07.2026 (10:30 बजे पूर्वाह्न)
6.	निविदा आमंत्रित करने वाले पदाधिकारी का पदनाम	कार्यपालक अभियंता का कार्यालय, पथ निर्माण विभाग, पथ प्रमण्डल, देवघर।
7.	प्रोक्चोरमेंट अधिकारी का सम्पर्क नम्बर	06432-299919
8.	ई-प्रोक्चोरमेंट सेल का हेल्पलाइन नम्बर	0651-2446007

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Coming to America... and staying longer than expected

The 48-team format was supposed to be football's biggest compromise. Three weeks in, it's produced the most unforgettable moments for the underdogs



GETTY IMAGES

R.K. Arjun

Every expansion in football history comes with the same warnings, and 48 teams were no different. Critics lined up early: bigger groups would mean more filler, more blowouts, a World Cup stretched thin. Then Cape Verde drew Spain 0-0 in their tournament opener, and didn't stop there. The Blue Sharks followed it up with a comeback to hold Uruguay 2-2, and a goalless draw against Saudi Arabia ensured that they were the smallest nation ever to reach a World Cup knockout round before Argentina finally shut them out 3-2 in extra time.

Egypt matched the mood, grinding past Australia on penalties for their first-ever World Cup knockout win. Norway, back at the tournament for the first time since 1998, took down Brazil in the round of 16 clash on the back of Erling Haaland's relentless finishing and Martin Odegaard pulling the strings. DR Congo held Portugal to a draw. South Africa quietly out-defended Mexico and South Korea to top a group nobody had them winning.

Age is just a number

Behind every shock result is a name that didn't exist in the football conversation a month ago. Vozinha, Cape Verde's 40-year-old goalkeeper, went from journeyman AFCON veteran to World Cup folklore with a seven-save shutout against Spain in his tournament debut. Yoane Wissa did something similar for DR Congo, scoring the nation's first-ever World Cup goal and dragging the nation past the group stage for the first time in their history. Switzerland's Johan Manzambi, barely a first-team regular at Freiburg before the tournament, came off the bench to score twice against Bosnia-Herzegovina and became the youngest Swiss player ever to score a brace at a World Cup.

From giant-killing draws to breakout heroes nobody saw coming, this World Cup has made its case in real time. Here is how the underdogs pulled it off, and it profiles the players whose World Cups went from anonymous to unforgettable.

Cape Verde's story isn't really about the three group-stage results anymore – those have been picked over enough. Facing the World Champion in the knockouts, they didn't sit back and hope to survive on damage limitation; they matched the *Albiceleste* for large spells and forced extra time before finally going down 3-2. For a squad built almost entirely around players from Portugal's lower divisions and mid-table European clubs, going toe-to-toe with Messi's Argentina for 120 minutes and producing a World Cup classic wasn't supposed to be possible.

For 79 minutes, Egypt had the World champion beaten. Two goals up with barely 10 minutes left, Mohamed Salah's



side had the great man's World Cup career on life support – until Cristian Romero, then Messi, then Enzo Fernández scored three times in the space of thirteen minutes to turn the game on its head. Which is really the point: Cape Verde and Egypt didn't bow out early because the gap in class was too wide. Call it bad luck more than failure: both sides played well enough to beat nearly any other team in the tournament; they just happened to run into the reigning World champion.

Making its presence felt

Paraguay had an impressive run in this edition after failing to qualify in the past. They endured a challenging path, finishing third in Group D with 4 points, which helped them progress to the Round of 32. *La Albirroja* made history by beating a German side stacked with talent 4-3 in a penalty shootout. They produced a spirited performance in the Round of 16 against a French attack led by Kylian Mbappe, Ousmane Dembele and Michael Olise, only conceding due to an unfortunate penalty in the 70th minute, which was calmly slotted home by the French captain, marking an unfortunate end to their fairytale run.

Norway's run wasn't a shock in the same sense – this is a squad with genuine world-class talent – but its absence from the quadrennial extravaganza since 1998 made its round of 16 win over Brazil feels seismic anyway. DR Congo's point against Portugal came from a team back at the tournament for the first time in over half a century, playing a compact, counter-punching system built specifically to frustrate bigger opposition. South Africa's unfussy, well-organised defending saw off Mexico and South Korea to top a group nobody outside the camp gave them a chance in.

None of this happens by accident; none of this happens in the old format either. Give a team one shot at a giant and most fold; give them a tournament's

worth of room to build a campaign, and you get Cape Verde forcing extra time against the champion or the Norwegian juggernaut running circles around the pioneers of *Jogo Bonito*.

Every World Cup produces a handful of players who arrive as afterthoughts and leave as household names, but the expanded format has made this one particularly generous with its spotlight. The first breakout: Yan Diomande. The Ivory Coast winger arrived in North America on the back of a breakout Bundesliga season (12 goals and 8 assists), but nothing quite prepared anyone for what followed. His performance against Ecuador in the opening group match was, by Opta's numbers, statistically unmatched by any player's first three World Cup games this century. That's not hyperbole from a hometown paper; that's a data point. A tournament with eight fewer slots might never have had room for an Ivory Coast squad building itself around a 20-year-old still finding his feet at club level. Johan Manzambi's rise was even less scripted. Barely a first-team fixture at Freiburg before the tournament, the Switzerland midfielder made his World Cup debut off the bench against Qatar and followed it with a brace against Bosnia-Herzegovina, becoming the youngest Swiss player in the tournament's history to score twice in a match. Reports linking him to a Premier League move surfaced within days. Nobody was scouting Manzambi for stardom in May. However, by July, he was on his way to the biggest league in the world.

Deniz Undav's story cuts even closer to obscurity. As recently as 2020, he was playing third-division football in Germany, and he didn't earn his first senior cap until 2024, at 27. Brought off the bench in Germany's opening two matches, he produced five goal contributions in limited minutes including an equaliser and a stoppage-time winner against Ivory Coast. It's the kind of redemption arc that is

usually present in movie scripts.

Then there's Yoane Wissa, whose importance to DR Congo went beyond a stat line. Scoring the nation's first-ever World Cup goal is one thing; doing it for a team that hadn't appeared at this tournament since it played as Zaire, over half a century ago, gave the goal a weight that outlasted the match itself. Wissa didn't just have a good tournament, he became the answer to a trivia question that will follow Congolese football for decades. Morocco's Ayyoub Bouaddi offered a different kind of surprise. Only 18, and a recent convert from the French youth setup, he needed just one half against Brazil to look like he belonged on the world stage, controlling a midfield with Premier League talent like Casemiro and Bruno Guimaraes. And in Cape Verde's own story, its centrepiece is Vozinha, a 40-year-old goalkeeper who'd spent his career on the margins of the sport before a World Cup debut turned him into a folk hero overnight.

A 32-team World Cup has less room for a gamble, which means fewer uncapped 20-year-olds, fewer bench options who'd spent 2020 in the German third division, fewer squads built around a diaspora of academy prospects rather than the 15 names everyone already knew. 48 teams meant more federations willing to take those risks, and this summer, an unusual number of them paid off in real time, on the sport's biggest stage. None of these players are finished stories either. Diomande and Manzambi will walk into their next club seasons as wanted men rather than well-kept secrets. Undav has already forced his way from afterthought to first-team consideration. Wissa's goal will outlive his career, cited every time DR Congo qualifies for another tournament. That's the real inheritance of this World Cup's size – not just the shocks it produced, but the careers it reshaped along the way.

Expansion was supposed to be a compromise. Instead, it turned into an argument for itself, told not in press releases but in stoppage-time goals and forced extra time, in unknown names becoming household ones. The real shift wasn't that small nations occasionally beat big ones; that's always been possible. It's that this format gave them enough matches, enough minutes, enough room to turn a single good night into a run of results worth remembering. Nobody will look back on this World Cup and think of it as diluted.

If anything, it exposed how much talent international football had been quietly leaving on the table every four years, simply for lack of space. Forty-eight teams didn't lower the ceiling. It raised the floor, and everyone from Cape Verde's back line to a German striker who was playing in the third division six years ago got to prove exactly how high that floor now goes.

THE GIST

Cape Verde matched defending champion Argentina for 120 minutes before falling 3-2 in extra time, while Egypt had Argentina two goals down with 10 minutes left before a stoppage-time comeback ended its run

Norway, DR Congo, and South Africa all wrote their own chapters into this World Cup's underdog story, each turning decades of absence or low expectations into performances nobody saw coming

The tournament also provided a global stage to players who'd have stayed unknown otherwise: from Diomande's record-breaking opener for Ivory Coast to Cape Verde's 40-year-old goalkeeper Vozinha turning his World Cup debut campaign into a folklore

Paraguay had an impressive run in this edition after failing to qualify in the past. *La Albirroja* made history by beating a German side stacked with talent 4-3 in a penalty shootout



S CH-CH

Text & Context

THE HINDU

NEWS IN NUMBERS

Average crude oil production in Nigeria last month

1.56 million barrels per day. Nigeria's crude production reached a 74-month high last month, authorities said over the weekend, hitting an average of 1.56 million barrels per day. Africa's largest oil producer has increased production in recent years in part by cracking down on theft while also hiring former militants who sabotaged pipelines to act as security. AFP

Aid pledged by the EU to help Moldova's air defence system

120 in € million. "The Council adopted an assistance measure worth €120 million under the European Peace Facility in support of Armed Forces of the Republic of Moldova to enhance the country's air defence capabilities," said a statement from the Council of the EU. Moldova's relations with Russia have been soured by Moscow's invasion of Ukraine. REUTERS

Decline in India's soybean meal exports in June 2026

69 in per cent. India's soybean meal exports fell nearly 69 per cent to 30,000 tonnes in June amid high prices and weak demand in major importing markets, the Indore-based Soybean Processors Association of India (SOPA) said on Monday. According to data made available by SOPA, 97,000 tonnes of soybean meal was exported in June 2025. PTI

Arrests ordered by Turkey ahead of coup anniversary

1,000 A decade after Turkey's failed 2016 coup, prosecutors ordered the arrest of nearly 1,000 suspects linked to an organisation that Ankara holds responsible, the Justice Minister said on Monday. On July 15, 2016 a rogue military faction made a short-lived bid to overthrow the government of President Recep Tayyip Erdogan. AFP

Rate of increase in India's exports in June 2026

15.5 in per cent. India's exports rose 15.5 per cent year-on-year to USD 40.41 billion in June, while the trade deficit widened to a five-month high of USD 30.43 billion due to a surge in imports, driven mainly by higher crude oil prices. Crude oil imports jumped 40 per cent to USD 19.32 billion during the month. PTI
COMPILED BY THE HINDU DATA TEAM

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Can biogas aid India's energy security?

India, which imports nearly 85% of its crude oil needs, remains vulnerable to global energy shocks. Over the years, it has pushed several initiatives to promote compressed biogas. Despite these efforts, progress has been limited; government support and incentives could provide a boost to the sector

EXPLAINER

V. Nivedita

Tensions in West Asia continue to keep global energy markets on edge. India imports nearly 85% of its crude oil needs, much of it from West Asia, and supplies faced disruptions due to the Israel-U.S.-Iran war. While the government has diversified its crude oil suppliers, around 90% of India's LPG imports still transit through the Strait of Hormuz, making any instability in the region a potential risk to India's energy security.

Over the years, India has pushed several initiatives to promote alternate fuels like compressed biogas to reduce dependence on imported fuel, tackle agricultural waste and support rural incomes. But despite ambitious targets and policy support, progress has remained limited.

The search for an alternative fuel

Biogas is a mixture of methane, CO₂ and small quantities of other gases produced by anaerobic digestion of organic matter. It can be processed and compressed to get Compressed Biogas (CBG). It is chemically identical to CNG; renewable, carbon-neutral and can be produced from waste. It can be used directly to produce electricity, heating or as an energy source for cooking.

India has also been trying to blend biogas into its gas supply for at least a decade. The push gathered pace in 2018, when the Sustainable Alternative Towards Affordable Transportation (SATAT) initiative was launched with a target of establishing 5,000 plants by 2023. Only 132 are completed as of June 3, 2026.

The Centre launched the GOBARdhan (Galvanising Organic Bio-Agro Resources Dhan) scheme to increase CBG production. Under this 'waste to wealth' programme, the government offered grants of up to ₹50 lakh per district for



A biogas plant at the Waste-to-Energy unit in Koramangala in Bengaluru. J. ALLEN EGENUSE

community biogas plants. ₹564 crore was earmarked for the purchase of biomass collection machinery, while ₹994 crore was allocated to build pipelines connecting biogas plants directly to the gas grid.

However, progress on the ground has remained limited. The lack of infrastructure, poor private investment, difficulties in accessing formal credit and high upfront cost of technologies have stalled progress. Financial support from the government can make biogas projects economically viable. Other incentives, like accelerated depreciation and tax holidays, would also help attract private players.

Impact on cultivation patterns

The development of biogas has been uneven across the world, with Europe, China and the United States accounting for 90% of global production.

Germany is one of the largest producers in Europe, along with France, Denmark and the U.K. The fillip for the sector came in 2000, when Germany introduced the Renewable Energy Sources Act to incentivise production.

Over the years, it introduced schemes to guarantee income to producers, gave bonuses to help operators increase their income and encouraged small-scale biogas plants. However, the country's push for biogas triggered a "corn mania", with maize cultivation rising sharply because it was highly profitable for farmers. Maize slowly started to replace other food crops. Over a decade later, the government was forced to step in and control this by introducing a cap on the use of maize in biogas plants.

This danger hits close to home. The Economic Survey 2026 noted that maize cultivation in India has increased sharply, potentially affecting crop diversity and food security. It noted that while the national maize yield increased from approximately 2.56 tonnes per hectare in FY16 to roughly 3.78 tonnes per hectare by FY25, the yields for soybeans, sunflower, rapeseed, peanuts and millets, among other crops, have either stagnated or declined.

While this trend could be attributed to technological advancements, ethanol pricing can be an important factor.

The government fixes administered

per-litre ethanol prices based on the feedstock used. The price for maize-based ethanol is higher, while the price for rice-based ethanol is lower. The price for molasses-based ethanol is fixed between the two. Between FY22 and FY25, the administered price of maize-based ethanol grew at a compound annual growth rate (CAGR) of 11.7%, making maize more lucrative for farmers.

While maize's area under cultivation and production jumped between FY22 and FY25, pulses output declined, while oilseeds and other cereals registered only modest growth.

India imports large quantities of pulses and edible oils to meet demand. Yet, instead of focusing on increasing production, the government's policy might inadvertently disincentivise farmers from cultivating them. Over time, this could increase India's dependence on imports and expose domestic food prices to greater volatility during supply shocks.

Denmark, which is targeting to use only biomethane in its gas system by 2030, offers a solution. The government discouraged the use of crops as feedstock, and the primary source is livestock manure and agricultural waste.

Government's action plan

In 2023, the National Biofuels Coordination Committee approved a mandatory blending obligation. Gas distributors have been mandated to blend CBG into their supply from FY26. It would start at 1% and rise to 5% by FY29. In her Budget speech in February 2024, Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman said the phased blending of CBG in CNG for transport and Piped Natural Gas for domestic purposes "will be mandated."

To meet these targets, the government is ramping up the establishment of plants.

The question is whether the government can replicate India's ethanol blending programme with CBG. In 2014, just 1.5% of petrol was blended with ethanol. By December 2025, it had hit 20%, five years ahead of the original 2030 target.

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▼ Biogas is a mixture of methane, CO₂ and small quantities of other gases produced by anaerobic digestion of organic matter. It can be processed and compressed to get Compressed Biogas (CBG)

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What is the India-Australia uranium supplies agreement?

What do the administrative arrangements mean for India's nuclear energy sector?

Kallol Bhattacharjee

The story so far:

During Prime Minister Narendra Modi's visit to Australia last week, India and Australia "finalised the administrative arrangements" required to enable export of uranium from Australia to India. These exports will be "exclusively for peaceful purposes and under International Atomic Energy Agency (IAEA) watch" under the Australia-India Nuclear Cooperation Agreement, 2015.

What does the latest development mean?

The finalisation of the "administrative arrangements" means that private Australian mining entities involved in uranium extraction will be able to conclude commercial contracts with Indian private sector companies and joint ventures. The participation of private

Indian entities in uranium exports from Australia adds a new chapter to India's energy journey, which was recently boosted by the SHANTI Act passed in December 2025, opening the nuclear sector to private players.

The timing of the announcement is significant, as it has come at a time when India's energy sector is under severe stress due to the U.S.-Israel attack on Iran. India is being forced to diversify and explore options to cope with short-term requirements by buying hydrocarbons from Russia, the United States, and Venezuela, while also planning for the future. The arrangements with Australia for uranium export are expected to help India meet its energy requirements in the future.

Why is this significant?

Australia holds more than a quarter of the global uranium reserves and has traditionally maintained a strict policy

regarding the supply or export of uranium to non-NPT member countries. According to the World Nuclear Association the countries that have received Australia's uranium include the United States, Japan, South Korea, France, Sweden, Belgium, Finland, the United Kingdom, and Germany. India is among the non-signatories, which are countries that chose not to sign the Nuclear Non-Proliferation Treaty.

Australia has been exporting uranium to countries with which it has "bilateral safeguards agreements", as it maintains that support for nuclear non-proliferation is among its "paramount" considerations. The "administrative arrangements" can be interpreted as further firming up of "bilateral safeguards" that were part of the Australia-India Nuclear Cooperation Agreement 2015.

India has an unblemished nuclear supply chain record and an ambitious nuclear energy programme. Though it is

not a signatory to the NPT, it signed a safeguards agreement with the IAEA in 2008 after India and the U.S. signed the nuclear deal, which was presided over by Prime Minister Manmohan Singh and President George W. Bush. Subsequently, the 48-member Nuclear Suppliers Group made a major move by exempting India from the list of countries with which they are prohibited from engaging in nuclear-energy-related business, thereby opening the gates for nuclear-energy-related supplies to India. This exemption has been the basis of several civil nuclear agreements that India has signed with partner countries.

What negotiations made this arrangement possible in 2026?

While Canberra and New Delhi have finalised the "administrative arrangements" now, negotiations between the two sides have been ongoing for nearly two decades. On November 12, 2009, during Prime Minister Kevin Rudd's visit to India, the two issues were addressed."

A joint statement issued during this visit said, "Mr. Rudd noted India's plans to meet its future energy requirements by exploring and developing all sources of energy, including nuclear, renewable and non-conventional resources. Both sides recognised the benefits of enhancing bilateral commercial exchanges of renewable and non-renewable energy

resources. The two Prime Ministers also agreed that energy security concerns are best met by reconciling the long-term interests of both energy-producing and energy-consuming countries through a truly open and competitive energy market. Both sides also expressed their willingness to join efforts which promote a cooperative response to any global energy crisis." The same joint statement also mentioned mutual commitment to oppose nuclear weapons. These negotiations led to the Australia-India Nuclear Cooperation Agreement, which was signed in 2014 and came into force in 2015.

According to World Nuclear Association, the "administrative arrangement" between India and Australia was 'finalised and became operational' after the signing of the Australia-India Nuclear Cooperation Agreement of 2015 and at least 300 tonnes of uranium were exported to India since 2018.

But it is understood, that uranium export was part of a 'test drive' as there were lingering concerns about Indian entities receiving Australian uranium. The latest announcement on the "administrative arrangements" and the emphasis on "exclusively peaceful purposes and under International Atomic Energy Agency (IAEA) safeguards" indicates that the 'test run' has paved the way for bigger commercial deliveries.

